Starlight

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/40851006.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by Swinging_Cloud

Summary

So maybe immediately leaving Etheria isn't the best move they could possibly do.

As eager as Adora is to bring magic back to the universe, she also just wants to sleep. Her mind races with everything that's happened in the past 24 hours- defeating Horde Prime, nearly dying- multiple times- in the Heart of Etheria, releasing the magic, but also-

But also-

Catra kissed her.
And she wants to do it again.

Notes

Hi, lovely readers! I have left the comfort of my Brittana fanfics to write this, because after I finished SPOP (nearly two years ago, lollll) I wanted to read a fic like this and couldn't find one. So. Here I am. I will probably not be writing any further SPOP fics, but if you dig my writing you can find my Brittana stuff on FFN under the same name. This fic is rated Mature because, with pretty much every story I write, there will eventually be smut, it's just how I roll. So strap in for that, I guess. ._.

This fic is dedicated to my best fren, Ace!! ilu bb.

Enjoy!!

See the end of the work for more notes

MAPS

wait- they don't love you like I love you

As tempting as another space road trip with her best friends sounds, Adora knows she can't just leave Etheria in the state it's currently in- there's too many loose ends, too many towns to rebuild, too much trust to regain. Mara's ship isn't exactly in pristine condition, either, and upon further consideration, she's really *not* in a hurry to be holed up in that giant, floating dumpster, after all.

Even still, running away with her best friends into space sounds awesome and irresponsible, and staying on Etheria sounds like an absolute drag, but with the high of winning and her adrenaline from the recent fight both waning, Adora, despite her enthusiasm for whatever their next Best Friend Squad adventure will be, just wants to sleep.

"You look tired," Bow comments at last to no one in particular, breaking the lingering, comfortable silence that had fallen over them, now that the excitement is fading and reality is starting to settle in.

"I'm exhausted," Glimmer agrees. "I feel like I could sleep for thirty years." Truthfully, she isn't eager to be back out in the cold, empty blackness of space, utterly cut off from her magical connection to the planet, either- but she knows, after everything they've been through, that she will never leave Adora's side. "It feels like it's been *forever* since we've been able to really rest."

"Well, we're all safe now," Adora breathes, as if she can't quite believe her words' meaning is real. "Whatever else needs our attention can definitely wait- maybe not thirty years, but at least until morning."

Glimmer sighs, despite her smile at Adora's words, and covers her face with her hand as she remembers… "I'm sure Bright Moon is a *mess*. I'm not ready to go back there and face it yet."

"Who says we have to go back *now*?" Catra wonders. "We still have our stuff set up in the," she struggles for a moment at what to call it, and finally settles on, "hideout."

Adora's eyes light up from the reminder, from the idea that they can steal away from their impending responsibilities for just a little bit longer. "We do! And- it's quiet there." Without intending to, she smiles at Catra, her endless blue eyes impossibly soft and warm in a way that makes Catra's heart pound- how does she do that? "We can rest there," Adora continues, snapping into leadership mode, her voice serious and business-like, "and tomorrow, we can figure out what's next."

Bow glances over his shoulder at the group of princesses still celebrating, lost in their own worlds. "Should we-?"

"We'll catch up with them later," Glimmer shrugs, rising to her feet in answer. "I just want today to end." She grabs Bow and Adora's hands, then pauses to give Catra a pointed, expectant look. Catra glares in response, but reluctantly holds out her hand, consenting, and seconds later, in a flash of sparkles, they pop into existence in the hideout.

Catra ignores the turning of her stomach that always accompanies Glimmer's magic, standing in the center of the cave they'd been using as their base of operations for weeks. She tries to stop her head from spinning by reorienting herself with her surroundings- unsurprisingly, they look the same as they did the night she left. Her gaze makes its way around the room; she hears before she sees Entrapta already at her eerie, glowing workstation, explaining to New Hordak (formerly Old Hordak) in hushed, excited tones the intricacies of how she finally managed to override all of Horde Prime's control chips, and other nerd stuff Catra doesn't much care to think about.

As Adora, Glimmer and Bow move to debrief with Castaspella and King Micah and send them off, Catra hangs back, lost in her thoughts about the previous days. A quick, guilty glance reveals her sleeping bag beside Adora's- both of them neat and made, though she'd left hers a mess in her haste- and her pulse races suddenly at the memory of Adora's tearful face and anguished cry of her name, at the thought of Adora tidying her bedroll in her absence, at the reminder that they still have so much to talk about-

Melog mewls beside her, drawing her out of the painful memory, and she's surprised by their presence- she didn't realize they'd followed her back to the cave. She reaches out absently to greet them, placing her hand on their head, grounding herself.

Sleep?

The suggestion sounds wonderful. She hadn't slept the night before, consumed with dread at the thought of losing Adora, terrified of witnessing it and being unable to stop it. Her emotions had nearly consumed her, and she felt drained from the extreme and sudden switches between the highs and lows.

"Hey," Adora says softly from behind her, and her left ear twitches in surprise at having been so lost in thought she didn't sense her approach. She can normally hear her big, dumb footsteps.

When Catra turns, she finds Adora offering the bag she had left behind the night she'd literally disappeared, and she frowns as she gingerly accepts it, her ears flattening guiltily.

"Thanks," she mutters, and they stand in silence for a moment before Adora, vibrating with tension, takes a deep breath and sinks down to her sleeping bag, her body screaming with fatigue.

Adora knows they should talk about things- they have so many things to talk about, after all- but she also knows that she does not have the energy, physically or emotionally, to sort through any of it. She tries to ignore the way her attention is unwillingly drawn

to Catra, even as she slips off her own red jacket, her boots, and, after a moment, her hair tie, shaking out her blonde hair for the first time in what feels like days. She slides her legs under the covers, hyper aware of Catra settling into her own sleeping bag- *right* beside her- and holds her breath.

It all feels surreal. It seems like a lifetime ago that she'd woken up to find Catra gone; the memory makes her heart clench painfully. She glances over to find Catra staring at the door, as if remembering the same moment, her tail curling around herself like a barrier of protection against the sadness.

"Why'd you do it?" Adora whispers beside her, her throat tightening. She does not have the energy but she cannot stop her mouth from forming the words, her heart from pursuing the answer. She shivers, her stomach clenching as she recalls the feeling of having that same heart ripped from her chest, the feeling she had when Catra left. "Why'd you leave?"

"You still don't get it, huh," Catra mutters quietly, shaking her head.

"Is it because you-"

"You're really gonna make me say it again?"

Adora smiles, barely, her blue eyes dull and sad. "Is that so terrible?"

Catra sighs in defeat. "Because I love you, Adora. And I-" her throat tightens. "I didn't want to watch you die. I *couldn't*. Not after everything I…" Her voice shakes. She swallows.

"I love you, too," Adora whispers. "But that never stopped *you* from trying."

Catra smiles bitterly, her ears lowering in guilt. "I know a lot of bad shit has happened and I tried to kill you a lot, but I never really believed I would actually *succeed*."

At the raw confession falling from her lips- for the first time out loud- the accusing, harsh words of Double Trouble return to her, echoing cruelly in her mind.

We both know this was never what you really wanted.

Catra squeezes her eyes shut, trying to block out the painful memory, the sting of the betrayal, the sharpness of their truth, and her words tumble out faster. "I knew you'd always find some stupid way to survive- you're so damn *stubborn*. Was I ever actually surprised when you showed up again?"

"I guess not," Adora admits.

"There were times when it seemed like you *wouldn't* actually survive, and I- I intervened. But with the failsafe-" she pauses, her voice wavering, and she glances at Adora's chest, remembering the glowing evidence of the failsafe that was once there. "It felt- *real*. It felt like you might actually really die, and I couldn't intervene, and I…" Adora reaches for her trembling hand, and Catra, feeling encouraged, continues, "I couldn't watch you leave me again." She squeezes her eyes shut once more, willing herself not to cry. Melog mewls sadly beside her in empathy, lying their head in her lap. She absently touches their head.

"Wow," Adora starts softly, slowly, and then, in a far more teasing tone, "I can't believe you *like* me."

Catra chuckles, discreetly scrubbing at her eyes with the back of her wrist. She shoves Adora playfully. "Idiot."

Feeling accomplished at lightening the subject enough to continue, Adora's expression grows soft, and she touches Catra's arm. "Hey," she starts gently, voice barely above a whisper. "I never wanted to *leave* you; I wanted you *with* me. I still do. And all my choices- everything I envisioned for the future- you were *there*, Catra… by my side. The backgrounds might have changed but- it's always been you and me."

"Well, gee, I wish you would've told me before."

Adora scoffs, her eyes narrowing. "Like *you* told me all *your* feelings?"

"Yeah, I'm sure that would've gone over real well in the Fright Zone," Catra rolls her eyes. "And Shadow Weaver would've found some way to punish me for-" she pauses, the memory resurfacing in sharp, stinging clarity, seizing her chest in a sudden, cold grip. She takes a deep breath, trying to shake the feeling; she's not ready to sort through that. She doesn't know if she ever will be.

As if sensing the shift in energy, Adora creeps her hand into hers, holding it gently but firmly in their shared sadness, and Catra distracts herself with the contact, directing her focus instead on the feeling of Adora's fingers entwined with hers as Melog lets out a soft purr beside her. Holding Adora's hand used to come so easily- there was nothing to sort through, nothing to analyze, just the two of them taking on the world together. It felt so natural.

But now, everything's shifted; she still gets an excited, comforting feeling from the gesture, but there's *more*- a weight there that didn't exist before. Her tail flickers in thought.

Adora's heart pounds, her body responding to the magnetic fire of Catra's close proximity. She's always felt an indescribable energy whenever Catra is with her; she never knew what it was or what it meant, only that she desperately wanted to be around her- closer to her- always.

Now, with their feelings out in the open, Adora starts to recognize that want as attraction, and the realization of it nearly takes her breath away. A thousand questions fill her mind, and she wonders- has she *always* wanted Catra?

The sudden bombardment of thoughts reminds her that she does not have the power to sort through them, and despite the fire filling her from Catra's nearness, she's still so very, very tired. "We should get some sleep," Adora says quietly, more to convince herself than for any other reason, and Catra nods absently, her thoughts drifting as Adora reluctantly releases her hand.

They shift down quietly into their separate sleeping bags, subconsciously facing each other. Adora stares at Catra's lips; the memory of them pressed up against hers still doesn't feel real, but it ripples through her, sending heat flashing to her lower stomach, which confuses her, because her body is still insisting that it's beyond exhausted.

She aches to be closer to Catra, but she's unsure what the rules are now- she'd never kissed anyone before today. She's caught herself staring at Catra's lips many times, but never gone so far as to imagine them locked in a passionate embrace. Now, though, she has the memory of how it felt to kiss her whispering in her mind, and the same gaze at Catra's lips kind of drives her crazy.

Melog curls up against her back, their form pressed against her, warm and comforting. She secretly longs for it to be Catra instead, but doesn't know how to voice her desire, and her exhaustion is relentless. As she forces her gaze up to familiar, intense eyes, focused on her, she tries to ignore the loud, conflicting feelings- the ceaseless tugging in her chest, countering her fatigue- because she's unsure what to do about it. She just wants to be closer, but insecurity makes her second-guess herself. What if Catra rejects her? They hadn't shared a bed since Mara's ship, despite being inseparable otherwise, and she's pretty sure, in her vulnerable, exhausted state, that she would cry if that happens, which would ruin the peace that had settled over them. Her thoughts race as she debates internally, and when Melog shifts behind her, she's reminded that they reflect Catra's emotions, *so maybe* -

"Come here," Adora breathes finally, opening her sleeping bag in brave invitation. "Please- I- I want you near me."

"I *am* near you, dummy," Catra mutters, but she shifts closer in response, sliding into Adora's warm sleeping bag and finding her familiar spot against her. Adora slips her arms around her, pulling her close, then closer, into a hug, and Catra slides arms around her waist, tucking her head under her chin and breathing in Adora's living scent. Melog presses in even closer to Adora's back,

and with the warmth and comfort of Catra surrounding her, and the low, steady hum of Catra purring against her chest, she's finally able to sleep.

Bright Moon is less of a mess than they expected, once they finally realize they can no longer put off returning to it and Glimmer teleports them to the palace. It's not perfect; there's a lot of sections in desperate need of rebuilding, but the palace- and, more importantly, the Moon Stone- stand relatively untouched by Horde Prime, in thanks mostly to them abandoning it early in the fight and making it less of a target.

Netossa and Spinerella had forgone sleeping in the cave the night before and had instead returned immediately to Bright Moon, eager to get an early start the next morning on organizing the chaos. By the time the Best Friend Squad arrives, the Captain has already regrouped with the rest of her guards and secured the palace as the previously-evacuated citizens begin pouring back into the kingdom. Glimmer, Micah and Adora, trailed by Bow, Catra and Melog, spend the remainder of the day walking through the town, encouraging the slowly-returning citizens, and joining Spinerella and Netossa at the supply lines to help dole out supplies.

With her new short hair and change of outfit rendering her unrecognizable to the majority of the people of Bright Moon, Catra quietly observes the awe and gratitude on display as the citizens bow and cry before King Micah, lost to them for so long. Glimmer proudly revels in the attention, happy to show off her father, who stands awkward under the unwanted publicity while Catra attempts to stay in the shadows.

When the sun begins to set, and most of the Bright Moon refugees have been attended to, Glimmer allows herself to get lost in the excitement of bringing her dad home to the palace, even though he'd already been there for weeks without her, distraught over her disappearance and the slowly encroaching, advancing forces of Horde Prime.

As she follows Adora and the others down the palace corridors on the unneeded tour meant for Micah but useful for her, Catra feels uneasy, as if she doesn't belong here, doesn't deserve to stand in such splendor after all the hurt and havoc she'd caused. The halls seem sterile, empty, reminding her of her time spent on Prime's ship, despite trying to convince herself otherwise- but this big, empty structure is just as foreign, just as unwelcoming, and she struggles to keep her emotions under control, hoping her tail doesn't betray her.

The only thing keeping her from fleeing in shame is the firm, gentle pressure of Adora's hand in hers, anchoring her there, and Melog's reassuring presence beside her. She wonders how Glimmer can be so forgiving- after all, is it not her fault that Queen Angella was lost to the portal?

Then again, Entrapta *created* the portal machine, and they'd all forgiven her, and Catra knows she's at *least* as deserving of forgiveness as Entrapta, right?

She studies Glimmer, who shows no trace of sadness as she yanks King Micah along by the arm, giggling with excitement as she and Bow nearly fall over themselves sharing stories of their antics over the years. She listens quietly, observing, and when Adora chimes in with stories of her own about the three of them, she can't help the jealousy that overtakes her. With the exception of the parts she was present for- the *fighting* parts, the *bad* parts- three years of Adora's life are completely unknown to her. Her mouth tastes bitter at the thought, her stomach churns; Melog's blue seems to shift to a dull gray, and Catra wishes her emotions weren't so openly on exhibit.

But then Adora smiles that dumb, hopeful smile, just for her, her blue eyes shining, happy- and Catra feels her jealousy melt away. It's then that she realizes that the stories are just as much for her as they are for Micah- that the three of them are just as eager to let Catra in, to catch her up, to share their adventures with her, as she is desperate to fill in Adora's three-year gap.

Glimmer doesn't treat her with malice. When their eyes meet, not a single shred of hatred is present.

If Glimmer can forgive her, she decides, then maybe she can forgive herself.

It's a weird sight, seeing Catra in her bedroom, despite having fantasized about it constantly over the last three years. Glimmer hadn't bothered to assign Catra a room, and the knowledge that Glimmer automatically assumed that they'd want to bunk together makes Adora smile proudly. She watches Catra, who gazes around her bedroom cautiously, and hopes she wasn't wrong- but maybe Catra *does* want her own space. Out of desire, they'd shared the brig on Mara's ship, and once on Etheria, slept near each other every night; Adora remembers the old Catra sleeping at the foot of her bed, drawn to her- but that was before she became a Force Captain, with her own room, her own large bed. Does she prefer that now?

The fact that she doesn't know, that she hasn't known Catra for the last three years makes her second guess herself, hesitate. She clears her throat, watching Catra's ears perk up.

"Catra?" she calls gently, and Catra turns, her eyes wide. "I know it's a lot," she continues softly. "Believe me, this is the toned down version."

"It's just- so *pink*. How do you sleep in here?"

Adora laughs. "You get used to it."

Catra's quiet for a moment, her tail flicking in thought. "I guess they don't call it *Bright* Moon for nothing."

Adora slowly moves closer. "I know it's- different." When Catra doesn't answer, Adora chews her lip, her fear resurfacing. "Look, you don't have to stay here with me. I can ask Glimmer-"

"No, that's not it," Catra says quickly. The thought of leaving Adora's side, of being parted from her, is nearly frightening so soon after everything that's transpired. She'd spent three years sleeping without her- and she didn't want to do it anymore.

"Then what's wrong?"

"It's just- weird, being here. Seeing where you've slept- where you've lived- this whole time." *Without me.*

Adora's eyes soften, and she takes Catra's hand. "I didn't really sleep. Not like I used to in the Horde- it's too pink." They laugh together for a moment, and Adora feels encouraged. "But it'll be different now that you're here."

Catra rolls her eyes. "The room's still pink, Adora."

Adora only grins dopily in response, moving to her bureau as Catra finds a place to set her bag. She opens one drawer and begins making space for the few clothes Catra had managed to grab from the Fright Zone. The thought of Catra still wearing Horde clothes saddens her- at her soonest opportunity, she would have to set Catra up with the Bright Moon tailors. Even if she wanted the same clothes, like Adora did, it feels different not having them come from the Horde.

Not to mention the quality's better, too.

Once she finishes, she turns back to Catra to find her smiling softly at her, and she's once again gripped by the familiar desire to kiss her, to lean forward and taste her mouth, to run fingers through her short, choppy hair and pull her close, breathing her in… A blush spreads across her cheeks as she imagines it for the first time, slightly shocked by how fast her thoughts have taken off. She's about to give in to the pull, but a knock at the door interrupts her thoughts.

She calls for their visitor to enter, and the door cracks open to reveal Glimmer, grinning mischievously. "It's ti-ime," she sings.

Adora smiles at the familiar look- she knows there's only one reason she'd be knocking so late. She grabs Catra's hand and tugs her to the door. "Let's go!"

"What's going on?" Catra demands, but doesn't pull her hand from Adora's as they slip out into the hall, where Bow- and Melog, who had been given their own room- stand waiting for them.

Bow and Glimmer exchange looks, and then he turns accusing eyes at Adora. "Adora, you didn't tell her?"

"Tell me what?" Catra complains. Melog echoes the sentiment.

Glimmer wraps her arm around Catra's shoulders, causing her to frown. "We're going to raid Bright Moon's kitchen!"

When the realization hits her, Catra's expression softens. "Oh," she murmurs, her ears flattening, eyes averting to the ground. Adora squeezes her hand in excitement, and she feels an involuntary blush cross her cheeks. How could Glimmer forgive her, then so easily and purposefully include her in such a private Best Friend Squad outing? How does Catra deserve this?

Before she can ask any more silent, self-doubting questions, Catra is swept up in the excitement as Glimmer releases a battle cry and they teleport through the palace and into the kitchen. Catra takes a deep, calming breath, centering herself- she supposes it gets easier each time Sparkles does it- as they all pause to take in the kitchen and find it exactly how it had looked so many times before.

On the counter, posed on an elegant platter, sits a giant cake, and Glimmer easily lifts it, offering it to her friends. Before they can ask about the cake's origin, since the Bright Moon chefs had not returned yet, Glimmer admits, "I *might* have called in a favor from Erelandia."

Catra swallows, her throat feeling tight with emotion at the obvious lengths Glimmer went to in order to have this special

outing with her friends- with *her*- as Bow agrees, *they definitely owe us!*

They circle up on the floor with the cake platter in the center, dividing the lime green-colored confection up equally among them. Unsurprisingly, Adora finishes hers first, making the rest of them laugh at the frosting and crumbs that cover her face. She tries to steal the rest of Catra's cake next, and Catra makes a big show of keeping it away from her before finally surrendering… but only after wiping a large smear of frosting across Adora's face, which prompts Adora to tackle her and rub her face against Catra, who shrieks and struggles away, and they all laugh so hard they cry.

When the cake is finished, and they're pumped up on sugar and happiness, Glimmer's eyes sparkle with their usual magic. "I can't believe we're here," she breathes.

"It seems unreal," Bow agrees. "After so long…"

"A lifetime ago," Glimmer admits, her gaze turning sad.

Adora pauses to reflect as the energy between her and her friends takes on a melancholic tone. It had been a long time since they'd all been okay- she and Glimmer had had tension for a while, and then there was Bow and Glimmer's tension, and Catra-

Almost against her will, a smile overtakes her face. She'd only ever dreamed that Catra would join the rebellion, only ever secretly hoped they'd be laughing together like this on the floor of Bright Moon's kitchen. Now, with her dreams a reality, she feels complete- not for the first time since Catra had joined them. She only hopes that Catra feels the same way.

Glimmer is first to rouse from her thoughts and climb to her feet, and Catra sets the empty platter on the counter. Once they are all standing, Bow pulls them into a long, silent hug, and for once, Catra allows herself to melt into her friends, to take comfort in the physical expression of their love, to feel their joy at her presence.

They cling to each other tightly for long moments, and finally, once they separate, offering each other smiles and good nights, Catra and Adora tread silently back to Adora's room, hand in hand down the dark, empty- but now familiar, not-so-unwelcoming, *safe* - halls of Bright Moon.

Melog peels off down another corridor with a soft mew as they reach Adora's room, and once they're inside, closing the door behind them, Adora pulls Catra into a tight, intimate hug.

"I can't believe *you're* here," she whispers.

"Where else would I be?"

Adora's smile falters. For so long, Catra had been elsewhere, everywhere but here where Adora knew she belonged. She doesn't allow herself to get lost in regret, in bittersweet longing for the past to be different, and instead, focuses on the present, and her best friend in her arms. "I'm sorry," she admits. "Having you here just feels- right."

Old Catra would say something sarcastic- would tease her, shut down such an honest admission of emotion, because her heart couldn't take what it could mean. But instead, her expression softens. She returns the embrace, nuzzling into Adora's neck.

"Get used to it."

Adora smiles, squeezing her tighter. "Gladly. It's all I've wanted. I missed you so much."

Catra swallows, feeling too many emotions. "I- missed you, too."

Adora pulls back, and once again, desire clenches in her stomach- especially when she notices Catra's eyes gazing at her mouth. Her heartbeat picks up, and she bites her lip. "Catra," she starts, low, shy. "Can I-" she hesitates, mustering up her courage. "Can I kiss you?"

This time, Catra can't stop from rolling her eyes. "Adora, you don't have to ask every time."

Adora blushes furiously. "Okay, well, it's kind of a new thing for me, and I've never kissed anyone before, so- "

"You haven't?" Catra asks, raising her eyebrow in challenge.

Feeling slightly judged, Adora's eyes widen in shock. "You *have*?" And at Catra's sly nod, she finds her stomach twisting. "Who?"

Catra shifts closer, her forehead pressing against hers, her short bangs tickling Adora's skin. "You, dummy."

Relief washes over her- she really didn't like the thought of Catra kissing anyone else- and she sighs. Then, as if realizing the weight of expectation, she reaches up to cup Catra's face, her thumb stroking softly over her velvet cheek. With a shaky breath, she closes the gap between them, her lips pressing softly to Catra's. The grip of desire squeezes tighter in her stomach, and she doesn't know how that can be possible- is she not already satisfying it by kissing Catra? She kisses her harder, but the desire only grows, causing her heart to slam in her chest, and she pulls back after a moment, breathless, already desperate to kiss her again.

She licks her lips, nearly trembling from the powerful wave of emotions crashing over her. "Catra, I-"

And she's cut off by Catra kissing her, by Catra holding her, by Catra's fingers in her hair, stroking gently, then not so gently as her hold tightens, as her kiss turns fierce. Catra's tongue darts out against her lips, and Adora sucks in a quick breath, opening her mouth automatically. The kiss deepens; Catra's mouth is hot against her own, and Adora feels her pulse pounding loudly in her own ears, throbbing between her legs, especially when Catra's hands slip under the bottom of her shirt and her fingers graze along the heated skin of her lower back. They both groan at the touch; Catra from the warm, taut muscle she finds there, and

Adora from the possessive, teasing touch along her skin. She feels as if she can’t get close enough- the desire to touch Catra is nearly overwhelming, but she can't bring her hands to leave their spot cradling Catra's face.

For all she’d been dreaming of Catra’s mouth on hers again, this kiss is entirely different from that first loving, tender one in the Heart of Etheria, entirely different from what she’d imagined and expected. Catra ignites something powerful with her lips, with her tongue, with her sharp fangs nipping gently at Adora’s bottom lip, causing her to tremble with want she cannot yet name as a small, involuntary moan works its way up from the back of her throat and her hips press forward of their own accord, aching to be closer.

When they finally break apart, breathless and overwhelmed, their eyes meet, dark and intense. Adora’s heart pounds so hard she wonders if Catra can feel it, hear it. And then Catra speaks, her voice low, rough, scratchy.

“It’s late,” she admits. “We should sleep.”

Adora swallows her disappointment. She’s desperate to keep kissing Catra, nearly dizzy from the feeling, and she doesn’t know why it almost hurts to stop, but she does know Catra is right. She runs a hand through her hair, pulling her messy bangs from her forehead, feeling slightly frustrated without reason. “Okay,” she agrees finally.

They’re in their pajamas moments later- matching gray tanks and shorts, and Adora smiles wistfully at the familiarity. When’s the last time they’d been safe enough to be in pajamas together? Mara’s ship, after she’d rescued Catra from Horde Prime, but before?

They climb into bed, and Adora offers her a bright, hopeful smile, ignoring the way heat and desire simmer under her skin. “I love you,” she says, feeling the truth of it warm her chest, resonate throughout her whole body. It feels more real each time she says

it, and she reaches out to gently run her fingers through Catra's hair.

Catra smiles softly, leaning into the touch, her tail curling around Adora’s bare thigh, comfortably possessive. “I love you, too.”

Adora presses a gentle kiss to her temple as she curls up against her, as their legs tangle together under the sheets and they sink down into pink softness. She sighs in content, and as she mumbles a sleepy, *good night,* the last thing she sees are the stars, shining, brilliant, through her window.

Your Best (Etherian) Girl

Chapter Notes

Hi, again, dear readers! :)

Thanks to everyone who read the last chapter! Extra thanks to everyone who left kudos! And extra special thanks to those who commented! I appreciate the feedback and hope you enjoy this second chapter. It does get a little spicy, so keep that in mind. :3

Also, You may have noticed that this story is now 4 chapters long instead of 3. I realized writing this one that not everyone likes to sit through 10k words at a time, so I decided to split it up. It's for the best, lmao.

Enjoy~

but big spoon, you have so much to do
and i have nothing ahead of me

Adora feels her heart racing, but in a different sort of way than what she's used to before a battle- it's a way she's only ever felt around Catra, but even now it's different- shifted somehow. It's finally started to sink in- really sink in- that Catra is here, that Catra is *hers*, that everything that happened in the Heart of Etheria wasn't some crazy, poison-induced fantasy. Kissing Catra last night, sleeping in her arms, confirming their love- it's all real.

She feels- edgy. As if energy is pulsing under her skin, causing her blood to race in her veins, her heart to pound in her chest, so different than when she's She-Ra. She can only attribute it to the fact that now she can name her feelings, when before they were shrouded in confusion and mystery.

She searches for Catra's eyes across the Bright Moon war-table, and the words she'd tearfully confessed in the Heart of Etheria

replay in her mind. Catra's loved her this *whole time*- and she knows deep in her own heart that she's always loved Catra; her feelings haven't changed just because she can *name* them now.

But when Catra meets her eyes, and her heart skips a beat, she knows there is *more*. When Catra kissed her, it started a chain reaction, and now Adora can barely think of anything else. She can still feel the softness of her lips, the trembling touch of her fingers along her face-

"Adora?"

She snaps her attention to Glimmer, a slight blush spreading across her cheeks. "Yes?"

"Do you think it's a good idea for you to go with Catra to help Scorpia figure out what to do with the Fright Zone?"

Catra's looking at her, but not in the snarky, challenging way she expects. She's studying her with a soft, worried expression, and it's such a rare look that it makes her feel weak. Her eyes dart down briefly to Catra's lips, almost against her will, and she's reminded of the way they felt just that morning, when she'd woken up beside her, their limbs tangled together with the sun shining in, lighting up the room. She'd only meant to give her a sweet *good morning* peck, but when Catra's mouth opened, and their tongues met, she'd been drawn into something much more involved. She shivers, recalling the way Catra's hands stroked down her side, the way Catra stole her breath. Her stomach clenches, and the feeling of such intense arousal is so new to her that she can only nod absently in response to Glimmer, who turns her confused gaze back to her dad.

"Oookay, well, Adora said she'll go. That frees Bow and I up to go to Plumeria."

"Perfect, baby girl."

Catra's expression shifts, her smile turning sneaky, teasing- as if she somehow *knows* what Adora's thinking- and Adora bites her

lip. She's really not going to be able to function with Catra around, is she?

"Catra! Adora! Hi!" Scorpia greets enthusiastically, meeting them in the heart of the Fright Zone, near where Glimmer had dropped them off. "Thanks for coming- sorry about the mess!"

"What mess?" Adora wonders, taking in the beautiful blanket of colorful plants and flowers- left in the wake of She-Ra releasing the magic back into the planet- that covers the gloomy, green-and-brown palette of the Fright Zone.

"Perfuma's coming by later this week to help redecorate once she's finished with Glimmer and Bow, but Entrapta's requested we leave what's left of the Sanctum and the Black Garnet Chamber alone- at least until she gathers all the tech there to move back to Dryl," Scorpia explains as they walk through the dingy, dark halls, and as they move deeper, it becomes more apparent what *mess* she was referring to.

"There's a shocker," Catra mumbles. "So, what's the plan?"

"I was hoping you'd tell me."

"Well- I guess that depends on what you want," Adora says, her voice small as she takes in the destroyed remnants of the structure she once called home. It's still jarring, seeing it in such a ruined condition- so different from what she remembers, from what she sees in her memories. The Fright Zone had always been dirty and crumbling, consisting of ancient, outdated technology- but that was part of what made it familiar. Now, a variety of demolished Horde vehicles and pieces of smashed machinery litter the floors, lay ravaged in piles against walls- evidence from her battle with Chipped Scorpia.

Scorpia has no answer as they move deeper, through passages that still hold puddles of standing water; melted walls, jagged metal edges and deep gouges frame the hallways, remnants of

Catra's battle with Hordak. When they reach the Black Garnet Chamber, they find the large room- if they can even still call it a room- in even worse shape than what they'd witnessed leading up to it. The crystal, however, stands relatively untouched, despite the lack of a ceiling or sound walls to protect it.

They take in the destruction for a moment in silent remembrance of the battles they'd each fought there, and finally Scorpia says, soft and sad, "I want this place to feel like home again."

Adora nods in understanding, then raises her hand in the air. "Leave it to me- *for the honor of Grayskull!*"

Warm, blinding, golden light illuminates the room; Catra can't help but feel sentimental and a little bitter. She'd always been secretly fascinated and intimidated by She-Ra, and, though she would've never admitted it, impressed. It didn't matter what Catra did to her, She-Ra always overcame it, and that was something to be admired and respected. She-Ra's greatest weakness is Adora's fondness of *her*- and she could never allow herself to feel flattered or distracted by that before, but now, as she watches Adora shift into She-Ra, she revels in the raw, endless power before her, made even greater due to the recent release of planetary magic.

But as magnificent as She-Ra is, Catra can't help but loathe her existence, just a little.

"How did Hordak even build all this?" She-Ra wonders, lowering her gleaming sword, an ethereal glow surrounding her form.

"My family helped," Scorpia admits as she easily hefts a giant metal crate and tosses it aside, clearing a path to the outside.

"And Shadow Weaver probably used her magic," Catra adds, proud that her voice shows no trace of weakness, despite the lingering anguish in her chest. She misses Melog, but she's glad she left them in Bright Moon, if only so that she can hide her feelings. "And the rest was built over time by the people the Horde enslaved."

"Well, she's not the only one with magic. It's time for this place to disappear, for good."

Catra gazes around wistfully- ignoring the way She-Ra refers to Shadow Weaver in the present tense- eaten by nostalgia. Most of her memories growing up in the Fright Zone are bad; she never fit in with the other cadets, she was punished mercilessly for things beyond her control, she was treated as less than garbage and never given a shred of encouragement or compassion…

But the few, rare good ones, the ones that persist despite everything, the only shining perk that made all her suffering worth something is her friendship with Adora. Adora was the one she could be herself with, the one who cheered her up after she was shit on by Shadow Weaver, the one who stood up for her, made her laugh, held her hand-

Bitterness grips her heart again. And then she *left*. She squeezes her eyes shut for a moment, trying to push those feelings away; she knows she can't keep holding on to them, but it's so hard to let them go. Adora *left* her-

But she came back for her. Isn't that enough?

She gazes at She-Ra, who lifts her shining, golden sword high in the air, gathering power, and wishes that it was.

She-Ra pauses for a conflicted instant, holding her sword aloft, her face reflecting the emotions Catra is feeling herself, and their eyes meet. The unspoken, myriad of different shared feelings passes between them, and She-Ra offers her a small, hopeful smile- *Adora's* smile- and Catra returns it, feeling some of the heaviness in her heart lift.

This godforsaken place will disappear, but she and Adora? They'll *always* remain.

Good riddance.

She-Ra's expression shifts to one of determination, her smile never straying as she drops the sword with a mighty swing, sending ribbons of light into the heart of the Fright Zone. Flashes of bright color reflect off of the damaged walls and piles of rubble, incinerating a majority of the rubbish and leveling the remaining, abandoned buildings.

Catra finds her hand in Scorpia's claw as the blinding lights spread outwards to affect the entire expanse of the Fright Zone, with the exception of their location, the main structure. In their wake, the plants and flowers reappear, and in the center of what was once a decaying graveyard of tech, the original Horror Hall stands, restored to its former glory.

A quick glance at Scorpia reveals tears streaming down her face, and as the light fades, She-Ra turns to them, powerful, strong- but with that same dopey Adora grin. Catra's heart skips a beat.

"It's not finished," She-Ra says, catching her breath after releasing so much power. "But it's a start."

"It's just like I remember when I was little," Scorpia says quietly as She-Ra reaches for her other claw. With a sudden movement, she pulls them both into a tight, full-body hug. "*Thank you*."

The work doesn't end there; She-Ra is magical but the Fright Zone is huge, and there's still a lot to clean up. Over the next several days, many of the former Horde soldiers, lost and without purpose, wander back to the Fright Zone, and Catra suddenly finds herself facing vast amounts of people she's hurt.

Adora, on the other hand, is pulled in so many directions, she barely has time to see anyone; she does a lot of the heavy lifting and rearranging as Catra makes plans with Scorpia on how best to integrate the returning soldiers into her new kingdom. During the course of the week, they steal away for brief moments, all awkward smiles and blushes, just happy to see each other before they are called away again. At night they curl up in each other's

arms in Catra's old Force Captain bedroom, one of the few rooms not being remodeled right away.

It's a strange feeling, having Adora in her bedroom- and Catra wonders if it's the same feeling Adora had, seeing her in Bright Moon. It feels almost wrong, seeing her there- as if she doesn't belong, doesn't fit with the dreary aesthetic. Despite how many times Catra had imagined it, wished it, *willed* it to exist, seeing Adora standing there in her pajamas doesn't feel the way she thought it would.

"Is it weird?" she wonders that first night, afraid of the answer but knowing the truth. "Being here?"

"Yeah, a little," Adora admits, slowly sitting on the scratchy, blue blanket atop the stiff bed. "It's been so long since I've slept here. The sound of the machinery used to comfort me to sleep- it was so hard for me to sleep in Bright Moon, at first, without the noise. But now it just feels… foreign, I guess."

Catra nods absently, her tail flicking. "That's how I feel in Bright Moon," she whispers, and Adora stops to stare at her, studying her face, her thoughts jumbled; if Catra feels foreign in Bright Moon, then where is their middle ground?

"Catra," she starts, her voice low and calm, despite her fear of the future. "We don't have to stay there if-"

"That's not what I meant," Catra says quickly. "Sure, the room is too pink, and I have to get used to Sparkles barging in whenever she feels like it, but," her ears drop slightly as she turns shy, "you're my machinery, Adora."

It takes a moment for Adora to process her words, but once she does, her eyes soften, and she smiles warmly, reaching up to cup Catra's face, stroking fingers along her velvet cheek to end at the hinge of her jaw, where she absently plays with the small tuft of fur there. "I love you," she breathes, fervent.

Catra's eyes darken at the touch, at the look of intense passion in Adora's eyes, at the certainty of her words, and she wonders why she never confessed her love sooner, why she waited so long. Would Adora still have left her if she'd known? Would she still have chosen the Rebellion- and in the end, Shadow Weaver- if Catra had told her?

Would Catra have gone with her?

She forces the thoughts from her mind. As she'd told herself already, there's no use dwelling on the past, but being literally surrounded by their toxic environment doesn't help.

And, just the way they felt falling asleep every night together when they were kids, Adora and Catra can't wait to leave the Fright Zone.

On their second day, Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio show up, and both Catra and Adora feel their stomachs drop when they spot them wandering through the small, temporary camp.

"We're here for Scorpia," Lonnie says, her tone harsh as she pins them with her glare. "And that's *all*."

Rogelio growls his agreement, and Adora nods before leaving to fetch Scorpia. Lonnie crosses her arms, scanning her eyes over Catra, who not only *looks* changed but- there's a demeanor about her that Lonnie has never seen before. She's different, *softer*- just what the hell did the princesses *do* to her?

"What happened to you?" Kyle blurts, and Lonnie doesn't bother to silence him, for she is insanely curious, herself.

"What do you mean?" Catra demands, feeling her defenses raise automatically as she's confronted by her former- can she even call them *friends*? She'd never *not* felt judged by them, never been able to let her guard completely down; they weren't friends she would have ever chosen, they were friends of circumstance from their shared conscription into the Horde army.

"It's just- your hair," Kyle says lamely, unsure how to pinpoint exactly why Catra seems different.

"What, I can't get a haircut?" Catra snaps, her tail bristling.

"Don't bother talking to her, Kyle," Lonnie sneers. "She's still the same old Catra. We're done here."

As she turns away, Catra feels her heartbeat quicken- she knows, even if they aren't technically her friends, even if she's quarreled with Lonnie and played pranks on Kyle her entire life, they still mean something to her- and she promised she was trying to be a better person. It's that tiny reminder in her brain that drives her to say, "Lonnie- wait…"

"What? You've got something to say, you'd better just spit it out."

Catra takes a deep breath. "I'm sorry."

The look on Lonnie's face nearly makes up for the pride she's giving up in admitting her mistakes- she doesn't think she's ever seen the woman more shocked. Kyle, empty-headed as he is, clearly doesn't grasp the gravity of her confession, but that's okay- Lonnie does, and she's wronged her the most.

"You're… *sorry*?" she clarifies, her green eyes wide.

Catra nods. "I treated you- all of you- like trash, just the way I was treated. You didn't deserve it- you were loyal, and I guess I just felt- alone. I was unhappy with myself and I took it out on you."

The three of them stand speechless for long moments, and then Kyle speaks.

"I forgive you, Catra."

"Thanks, Kyle."

Rogelio growls in agreement, but Lonnie narrows her eyes. "I don't."

Catra's throat tightens from the sting of rejection. "Okay."

"You put us through hell, Catra. I don't know if I can ever get past that," she says, shaking her head, shaking away the bad memories. She studies Catra's face for a moment. "But- thanks. For apologizing- it means a lot."

Catra nods, and Lonnie holds out her hand in a gesture of truce. Catra accepts it, releasing the breath she'd been inadvertently holding.

"Hey! You guys came back?" Scorpia exclaims excitedly once she spots them.

"We came back for you, Scorpia!" Kyle responds, pumping his fist in the air.

Scorpia crushes them in a grateful hug, and Lonnie growls, "as I said, you're one of us. And we stand by our own. Now what do you need us to do?"

While they set to work helping with the rebuild, Catra sets to work making reparations; she can't give them- or anyone she's wronged, really- much, but she *can* show them that she's changed, that she's sorry, and for the first time in her life, she works side by side with her former subordinates. Within days, the former barracks become homes, the outposts become towns, and the Fright Zone transforms into something familiar, but new, and without realizing it, Catra does, too.

Later in the week, Perfuma shows up as promised and uses her powers to help with the redesign, insisting that the new palette be purple. She adds more trees, gives feedback on the new buildings, and uses plant muscle to help with the heavy lifting. Entrapta appears a day later with New Hordak, Wrong Hordak, and the rest of the clones- who have all taken to serving her in place of Prime- to collect her precious tech and invaluable research, and with the

threat of her wrath gone, they demolish the final building left from the Horde.

By the end of the week, Horror Hall has expanded and the new kingdom of Scorpia has the beginnings of a strong foundation; Adora and Catra feel accomplished that they turned something that had been a source of some of the worst times in their lives, a source of negativity and pain, into something hopeful, something good.

"So what about you?" Lonnie says, finally speaking her mind to Adora after days toiling next to her in fuming silence. She sets down her paintbrush pointedly, commanding attention.

"What?" Adora asks, looking up from the section of the building she's painting beside her. "What about me?"

"We never did find out what really happened," Lonnie says, glaring, accusing. "You just… never came back..."

Catra watches quietly as Adora rises to her feet, balking at what to say. She wants to defend her, to say it wasn't her fault, but the sting of Lonnie's words echo and resonate in her heart. How can she stick up for Adora when she can't get past it, herself?

Then again, how many times had Adora stood up for her, tried to take the blame, without knowing or agreeing with Catra's true reasons?

"Did the princesses brainwash you like they did to Catra, or...?"

"We were wrong, Lonnie," Adora says, gently but firmly. "The Horde was evil."

"No, *duh*," Lonnie snaps. "You can't tell me you *really* didn't realize that before?"

"I-"

“Give her a break,” Catra cuts in, her tone protective as she moves to stand beside Adora. “Shadow Weaver had her mind controlled- sheltered. She was never handled the way we were.”

“Shadow Weaver….” Kyle shudders.

Lonnie turns her glare to the horizon, as if looking towards the Black Garnet Chamber which no longer exists- Scorpia’s Runestone had been moved back to Horror Hall, where it belongs. “Where is she, anyway?”

“She… didn’t survive the battle,” Adora starts carefully, and Catra’s ears flatten involuntarily.

“Well, you know what they say,” Kyle starts cheerily. “No one mourns the wicked.”

But Catra stares towards the spot where the Black Garnet Chamber once stood, and her stomach twists with grief.

Their last night before heading back to Bright Moon for the ceremony placing Scorpia in charge as an official princess, they gather around a campfire in the new town, sharing war stories. Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio are intrigued to hear everything that had been going on behind the scenes that they were previously unaware of for years; Adora spends the evening explaining to them about the sword, and She-Ra, and-

“You’re a First One?” Lonnie says incredulously. “No shit!”

“That’s so awesome, Adora!” Kyle says genuinely.

Scorpia and Perfuma show up with sweets once it gets dark, and they spend the rest of the night laughing, sharing food, sharing stories, and for Catra, it brings back fond memories of their forbidden sleepovers, and their hangouts with the team, and maybe they *had* been her friends all along. The truth of it makes the weight of her actions even more difficult to bear, but she knew going into this that it wasn’t going to be easy to face everything

she’s done, everyone she’s hurt. It feels new, despite the old, familiar faces- she feels as if she can finally let her guard down. For the first time, she’s not paranoid about what they might be saying behind her back- she feels as if they genuinely accept her, and it’s slightly overwhelming, but a lot less exhausting.

She laughs and jokes and rags on Kyle just like the old days, and Scorpia sits beside her, their knees brushing as, this time, it’s their turn to share with Adora all of their zany adventures. The memories are bittersweet, but Catra separates the good from the bad, the necessary from the petty.

“We’ve been hiding out in the Crimson Waste,” Lonnie says finally, once Adora finishes her tale of the Heart of Etheria and defeating Horde Prime- but without relaying the kiss, a detail that does not go unnoticed by Catra. “We knew Hordak would never go there, and we remembered Scorpia’s reports of how awesome it was.”

“I don’t know if *awesome* is the word I’d use,” Adora mumbles under her breath.

“But maybe we’ll move back here,” Kyle says, hopeful. “Now that it’s safe again.”

“You're always welcome,” Scorpia nods. “You are *all,*” she glances meaningfully at Catra, “my family.”

Once in Bright Moon, Catra is grateful to finally be able to relax. Even with the drastic changes, being in the toxic environment of the Fright Zone kept her on edge, and she surprises herself with how relieved she is to be back in *Bright Moon*, of all places. She’s shocked to discover that she’s starting to think of the Bright Moon Castle as home, and Melog confirms her feelings when they greet her enthusiastically upon her return. Still- despite how painful being back in the Fright Zone was, transforming it- or demolishing it, really- gave her the closure she needed. She feels as if she can finally let everything that happened there go, even if she’s not completely healed.

She only gets a few days to relax, however, as preparations immediately begin for Scorpia's giant ceremony. Princesses and people from all over Etheria travel to Bright Moon, and on a beautiful, sunny day, Queen Glimmer names Scorpia the rightful ruler of the Lands of the Fright Zone and officially recognizes the Royal Scorpion Kingdom's place in the Princess Alliance. Scorpia herself is so touched that she pulls Glimmer into a hug, causing everyone to laugh.

After the ceremony, a huge, celebratory party ensues, and Catra and Adora spend the time with their friends, excitedly catching up and describing their days in the Fright Zone, while Glimmer, Bow and Perfuma recount their days in Plumeria. Adora listens quietly as she eats a slice of cake, enjoying the laughter and carefree, good-natured joking surrounding her, and feeling a lot lighter after closing the Fright Zone chapter of her life. She's surprised that even Catra seems in high spirits after their return, and she watches with interest as Catra and Scorpia tell Bow and Glimmer about a random encounter with a guy named Tung Lashor in the Crimson Waste. As they all break into peals of laughter, she can't help but think of how much she loves this side of Catra- the animated, charismatic side. Catra has always been great at telling stories, in part because of her expressiveness- and as tears fall down Glimmer's cheeks from laughing too hard when Scorpia dramatically says, *WHIP,* Adora can't help but laugh, too.

She'd be lying if she said she wasn't eager to steal away to her and Catra's shared room- if only to spend some time alone with her that she hadn't been able to really have for the past week- but she doesn't want to let these moments pass her by, either.

Bow wipes a tear from his eye and chimes in, "did you ever hear about the time we broke Wrong Hordak?" and Adora can only smile, nearly overwhelmed with happiness for the first time in her life.

Much later, full of delicious food prepared by the returned Bright Moon chefs, with their stomachs sore from laughing and their

cheeks sore from smiling, they slide into the fluffy, pink bed together, settling down under the blankets. Adora immediately curls up behind Catra as the big spoon, pulling her in close and breathing in her warmth.

"Do you regret it?" Catra asks into the silent darkness.

Adora nuzzles into her neck. "Regret what?"

"The kiss," Catra mumbles. "In the Heart."

Slightly confused, Adora raises up a little, propping herself on her elbow to study Catra's face, illuminated by slivers of starlight. "No. Why would I?" Then, after a moment, she adds, "do you?"

"No," Catra says quickly. "It's just that- well, you left that part out of your story, earlier."

Adora bites her lip. "Catra… I left it out because, I don't know, it sounds stupid, but- I want it to be *mine*. I felt like sharing it or telling people would be letting them into that private moment, and I'm not ready to give that up yet."

"We're going to have to tell people eventually…"

"Tell them what?"

Catra swallows, but doesn't have an answer. Are they together? Are they not? Are they best friends who just make out every once in a while? Or are they *more*?

"I don't think She-Ra was ever meant to be with anyone," Adora confesses in a whisper, trailing fingers down Catra's forearm, immune to the sound of Catra's heart shattering into a billion pieces at her words. "At least, that's what I thought. I always knew I'd end up alone- there was never any other option." She shuts her eyes, anguishing for a moment as she recalls her acceptance of her lonely fate- another part of herself, sacrificed *for the honor of Grayskull*. "If Light Hope had gotten her way, if Prime's virus had won- then that's how it would have played out."

Adora's blue eyes meet Catra's multicolor ones, and she reaches to cup Catra's face beside her, never tiring of the intimacy as her thumb strokes along her skin. She sighs, loving, as Catra's heart pounds with fear beneath her.

"Maybe She-Ra wasn't meant to be with anyone, but I'm more than her," Adora says at last, her voice confident, firm. "I'm- *me*. And I- I want to be with you, Catra. I can't picture my life with anyone else."

"I want to be with you, too," Catra says, voice scratchy with emotion. "I've wanted it for so long…"

"Then be mine, Catra. Because I'm yours."

Catra can only nod quickly, still recovering from the roller coaster of emotions she'd experienced in the span of about five seconds; she barely has time to process this new development before she's being drawn into a fierce, open-mouthed kiss. To say she's surprised at the hunger of Adora's kiss would be an understatement; she's normally the one taking their kisses deeper, pushing the boundaries, but this time Adora doesn't hold back, and Catra finds herself pulled close, closer, until she's drowning in Adora's scent, smothered by the heat of Adora's body.

When they finally part, Adora's heart is pounding, her breath coming in rapid, heavy pants as if she'd just sprinted several miles. Worried she might be on the verge of a heart attack, she takes several slow, calming breaths, finding Catra's eyes, glowing in the semi-darkness. She loves the way she can always find them, has always been drawn to them- no one else in the entire universe has eyes like Catra's, and she gently reaches forward to play with Catra's hair in reverent fondness, an echo of a gesture from when they'd have sleepovers as kids. Catra can't help the rumble of pleasure that rises up from her chest at the familiar touch- oh, First Ones, she's missed this- and she slowly slides her hands along Adora's bare, toned arms in response, their gazes never parting.

Adora traces exploratory, reverent fingers down Catra's face, down her neck, down the slightly-darker stripes on her arms, feeling the familiar form, but with new purpose and meaning; it is unfamiliar to her, now. It's then, lying on her side, her chest feeling tight, that she realizes that her touches mean something different than they did when they were kids. Her hand, so often at Catra's waist in the past, trembles and feels so heavy as she strokes along Catra's side now.

She had always touched Catra in ways she never touched anyone else. They were each other's only source of physical comfort, of intimacy, in the Fright Zone. She'd thought nothing of holding Catra's hand, of stroking her cheek, of pressing their foreheads together- but now, those same touches carry an unfamiliar weight that causes her to hesitate in an action she's performed countless times. It's a strange contradiction, touching Catra and knowing exactly how her familiar, soft skin feels, but also knowing that the way she's touching her is new and different- that Catra is new and different; she's older, changed, and Adora knows she's not the same, either. Her breath catches in her chest, and she's not the only one affected- Catra trembles beneath her hand, and Adora can hear her draw a shaky breath beside her.

They aren't kids anymore.

"You're perfect," Adora whispers, her tone a little awestruck.

"You know that's not true." Catra shakes her head slightly, pressing into the pinkness of the bed, her face slightly matching the color.

"You're perfect to *me*," Adora argues softly.

Catra smiles. "Maybe we're just perfect together."

Adora grins at her answer, liking it immediately, and then, as if magnetically drawn together, their lips meet, and Adora sucks in a shaky breath, heart pounding fiercely. Catra's smooth tail curls around the back of her thigh, the teasing caress making her

shiver, and then Adora pushes forward, rolling Catra onto her back as she tangles their legs together, all the while kissing.

Catra breathes her name; Adora trembles with want. Her hands slide up her sides, along her impossibly soft, silky fur, hesitant, pushing up her shirt to touch her stomach, warm and firm. She can't resist the overwhelming desire to touch Catra, to push their bodies together, to be *closer*. Catra's nails drag lightly up her back; her response is automatic, the way she arches, the way she moans, and without realizing, she grinds her hips down, making them both gasp in each other's mouths. Their foreheads press together and Adora struggles to breathe, then rocks her hips down again, listening to the soft hum of pleasure from Catra as she does.

Their lips meet again, hungry, fierce. Catra bites her lower lip, eliciting a low moan, and Adora crushes their bodies together. The pressure of Catra between her legs makes her stomach twist tighter, and she's nearly overcome with a hot, aching need, desperate to be closer, to satisfy- what? What is this feeling?

She growls in frustration, her heart pounding, her cheeks flushed. She pulls back, balancing her weight on her left hand which is planted next to Catra's head, her right moving upwards to cup her jaw, fingers stroking the soft tuft of fur beneath her ear.

"Catra, I- I want you," Adora pants, sending a shiver down Catra's spine.

Catra doesn't know what to say; she feels as if her soul has left her body, her heart beating frantically, stomach fluttering at the words she's longed to hear for years. Without thought, her hands slide up along Adora's ribs, pulling her close, and in answer, she cranes her neck to kiss the hollow of Adora's throat, and Adora tenses above her, her hips canting down involuntarily in response. Her mouth moves higher, up the side of her neck, and she can hear, feel, Adora's breath growing heavy, ragged, can feel her pulse against her lips. Adora's hips rock down against her again,

harder, and she thinks she must be dreaming; is this really happening? Does Adora really want her?

"Catra," Adora moans lowly as Catra's mouth continues along her neck and her tongue flicks out to taste her skin. Her hands grab fistfuls of the pink sheets on either side of Catra's head, and her arms tense as she struggles to hold herself up, but Catra doesn't hesitate to slide her hands along her bare thighs, teasing her with her nails. When Catra sinks teeth just barely into the base of Adora's neck, Adora gives her loudest sound yet: a low, strangled cry of pleasure, and Catra loves the way the vibrations feel in her mouth.

Adora's right hand fumbles along Catra's body, desperate to touch her; her hand slides along Catra's hips, her stomach, her thigh- all places she's never fully explored. Adora's hips keep their rhythm against her, and by the sound of her breathing and tiny whimpers of pleasure, Catra can tell that she's going to take herself over the edge soon- and she can't explain how badly she wants to feel it. She swallows her desperation, eyes glued to Adora's face as she chases her own orgasm against her, amazed that just touching her and kissing her has gotten her so wound up.

"I'm almost..." Adora whispers, and Catra wants to touch her so badly, wants to finish her, herself- but she knows she's not ready for that yet. Dry humping is one thing, but- "*Catra*-"

And then Adora tenses, and Catra would roll her eyes at how fast she finished if she wasn't too busy watching the most beautiful thing she's ever seen in her entire life. Adora's flexed, tense arms tremble from exertion, locked into position, her fists clenched so tightly they've turned white. Her thighs shake against Catra, bracketing her, and Adora's eyes finally squeeze shut, her mouth dropping open, silent.

After a long, tense moment, Adora lowers herself to Catra's side, her head gently finding Catra's chest as she rides out the aftershocks, her thighs clenching. Catra struggles not to get lost in her own bitter thoughts- reminded, once again, that three years

of Adora's life, Adora's growth- Adora's sexual awakening- are blank, missing to her. When Adora leans up to kiss her, open-mouthed and hot, Catra slows her pace.

Adora offers her a satisfied smile. "Wow," she says breathlessly.

"Don't ruin it," Catra teases.

Adora shoves her shoulder playfully before settling back down against it. It's silent for a moment before she admits, quietly, "I've never felt like that before."

Catra's heart catches in her throat. "Really?"

"Yeah." She presses a searing kiss to the side of Catra's jaw. "I want to make you feel like that, Catra."

Catra shivers involuntarily at the thought, but despite everything she's ever wanted being literally handed to her, something causes her to hesitate, and she wishes she could punch it in the throat. "I-" she starts, voice scratchy, as Adora's mouth moves down her jaw to her neck. She swallows, her throat moving beneath Adora's soft, warm lips. "I'm tired," she manages finally.

Adora pulls back. She studies Catra's face- she knows Catra's lying, and judging from the way her eyebrows furrow, Catra knows that Adora knows she's lying, but instead of pressing the issue, she smiles, her eyes bright, loving, icy blue, and it makes Catra's heart break. Why is she like this?

"Okay," Adora whispers, and she settles back down beside her, her head once again resting in its spot against Catra's chest. "Is this okay?"

No.

But Catra nods, because she can't bear to have Adora so close when she's still so bitter, but she craves it, all the same.

Posing

Chapter Notes

Hi, dear readers. :)

Here I am with chapter three! Thanks to everyone who read the first two chapters- I appreciate the kudos and comments. :))) I hope you enjoy this one, too, even though it's mostly feels. ;0; I swear this story will eventually get spicy, lmao i just like to work a lot of ~feelings into my smut, I guess. .___.

Enjoy! And thanks again for reading!! ~

and how could you ever conceive
how much i need you

"So…" Glimmer starts from her spot seated on the small couch in her room. She pins Adora with a demanding stare, belying her casual tone. "Wanna tell us what's going on with you and Catra?"

Adora immediately freezes, her back straightening. "Wha- what do you mean? Why do you think there's something going on?"

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Oh, come onnnn, Adora," she scoffs. "You've literally been pacing the entire time she's been gone."

"Yeeeah, we're not blind," Bow adds with a nod. "Also, it's well known that you're not really the best at lying…"

"The point is, we know something's up."

Adora sits down on a teal cushion across from her friends. She's not sure what, exactly, is causing her such unease, so she definitely has no clue how to explain it to them. "It's just- you

know, she's visiting Dryl with Entrapta," she starts finally, her eyebrows furrowing as she digs through her feelings, "and I'm just worried about the robots there still being, you know- out of control, or whatever?- and she's been acting really distant lately because I haven't told anyone about what happened in the Heart, and-"

"Woah, woah, woah, that's a *lot* to unpack at once," Bow cuts in.

"And what exactly *did* happen in the Heart?" Glimmer asks.

Adora blushes. "Well- Catra, she- she told me she's loved me this entire time-"

"*Obvious*, but go on."

"And we- *wait*, you *knew*?"

Glimmer laughs at Adora's clueless, shocked face. "Adora, please. Everyone knew."

"I'm pretty sure you were the only one who *didn't* know," Bow agrees. "You could probably see it from space, it was so obvious."

Adora's blush deepens and she narrows her eyes. "Wow, guys- thanks."

"Hey, it wasn't our place to tell you," Glimmer shrugs, holding up her hands in a surrendering gesture.

With a huff, Adora mutters, "Well, after she- confessed, or whatever- she- um, you know, she kissed me-"

She doesn't get the chance to continue, because Glimmer and Bow immediately start screaming. Adora feels her chest tightening; somehow, she knew her friends would react this way- it's why she didn't want to tell them in the first place, but she also knew she couldn't keep it a secret forever. Still… Catra went to Dryl on her own, igniting Adora's fears. It made her wonder if Catra would rather be elsewhere, if she's unhappy in Bright Moon,

and if Adora was somehow missing something important. Is she holding Catra back, keeping her in Bright Moon? Is she forcing Catra to finish in second place- this time, overshadowed by She-Ra- like she did their entire time in the Fright Zone? If she is, it will most certainly drive Catra away, and she *can't* lose her again-

"I knew it! Pay up!"

"Glimmer, I never even bet against you-"

Adora rubs her forehead in agitation. "You know, you guys are like *really* not helping."

"Helping with what?" Bow wonders.

She sighs, the tightness in her chest growing. "I don't know." When Glimmer and Bow wait patiently, she shrugs. She can't talk to them about her terrifying, real fears, because it would be admitting to herself that they exist, so she settles on, "I guess- I hope she's not mad."

"Catra's always mad," Glimmer jokes.

"Not at *me*," Adora protests, rising to her feet to resume pacing nervously. Why didn't Catra ask her to go with her? They hadn't been separated since Catra left her just before their big battle with Prime, and even though she knows- hopes- that this is not the same as that was, her heart can't help but beat with fear, her mind can't help but spin with worry- she can't help but feel the same.

Taken aback, Glimmer chews her lip for a moment, concerned for her friend, who's clearly not in a joking mood. She watches the dark cloud over Adora's head grow larger as the seconds pass, and finally she stands to place a comforting hand on Adora's shoulder, halting her steps. "Hey- I'm sorry. But I guess- if Catra *is* mad at you for not telling, then you've already fixed it by telling us, right?"

It makes sense in Adora's brain. She can't stand the thought of Catra upset at her- especially if she did something unintentionally- but it's worse thinking that she's inadvertently forcing Catra to compete with her again, though she has no idea what they would be competing for. The idea literally drives her crazy, and she feels consumed by a desperate need to make everything right immediately, to calm her terrifying, real fear.

"So... if she kissed you, are you guys- like, *together* now?"

Adora takes a slow, controlled breath as she realizes the weight of Glimmer's words, and after a long pause, she nods. "Yeah, we are."

"Adora, I'm so happy for you," Bow says genuinely, pulling her into a tight hug.

"I guess it's time we came clean, too," Glimmer admits. "Bow and I-"

"Oh, come on, Glimmer; I've known about you and Bow since Krytis."

At Glimmer's surprised shriek, Adora can't help but laugh.

As she stands, awkward but not uncomfortable, in an outfit expertly crafted by Bright Moon tailors in record time, Catra wonders if the rest of her life is going to be an endless string of parties, one right after the other, for as long as she's on Etheria and part of the princesses- and, inevitably, their princess bullshit. She'd spent a good amount of time in Dryl with Entrapta over the previous week, needlessly helping her sort through the tech she'd taken from the Fright Zone- even though she had an endless supply of clones to help her do such a menial task.

The alternative was going with the rest of her friends to Salineas to help restore the Sea Gate and palace, and although Catra felt like a coward for not being ready to face the Sea Princess's wrath, she'd much rather sort through dumb tech in Dryl.

She couldn’t avoid Salineas forever, however; once the work was done, Mermista had insisted on hosting a party in the newly-remodeled- once again thanks to She-Ra’s magic- palace, and Catra was forced to attend… as if she would make Adora go by herself, anyway.

As she stands alone by the wall, hiding in the shadows, she can’t help but think back to her first real party, with Scorpia, in the Crimson Waste- the first time she’d ever been happy since Adora had left her. (She doesn’t count Princess Prom, since she was technically working.)

The memory feels like ages ago, and with it comes the guilt of *after*- with Scorpia, with Adora, with the portal- but for that one moment in her mind, she was happy, accomplished, capable, powerful- everything she’d been told she could never be.

But Scorpia had always believed in her.

She gazes wistfully across the room at her friend, engaged in conversation with Perfuma, who seems to realize Catra’s looking in her direction. Perfuma catches her eyes from across the room, and offers her an encouraging smile, and Catra tries not to allow the crushing weight of her bad decisions take over what is supposed to be a celebration. She forces a smile in return.

“Isn’t this incredible?” Adora asks as she comes to stand beside her, handing her a glass of punch, and Catra can’t help but nod as she accepts. The magnificence of Salineas is truly one of the most awe-inspiring things she’s seen on Etheria; Catra isn’t a fan of water- in fact, she’d just as soon never go near the ocean again- and even she has to admit the palace is a wonder.

But nothing in the universe compares to the way Adora looks, elegant and dazzling in her usual red and gold and white. The sight of her makes Catra’s mouth go dry. To say she missed her while she was in Dryl would be an understatement, but she’s so afraid of the bitterness still locked in her heart. She’s mentally working up the courage to tell her how good she looks when she

senses someone behind her and the fur on the back of her neck bristles.

"It looks better than it did even before the Horde conquered it," Mermista comments from somewhere behind her. She turns warily.

"Hi, uh- Mermista," Catra stammers, secretly pleased that she remembered her name.

"Horde Scum," Mermista greets neutrally.

"Mermista, she's not in the Horde anymore," Adora complains. "The Horde doesn't even exist!"

Mermista shrugs nonchalantly. "She'll always be Horde Scum to me... And I mean that in the best way."

"Of course," Catra mutters, her ears flattening in guilt. She can nearly feel Adora bite her lip, can practically hear the mouse frantically running in a tiny wheel in her head, struggling to come up with something to say, and then Mermista speaks again.

"So like, are you two an item now, or what?"

Catra freezes, her ears perking straight up in shock, and she's assaulted with the heat of Adora's fierce, sudden blush beside her. She doesn't know what to say, though she knows what she *wants* to say. She's reasonably certain that Adora had told Bow and Glimmer during her absence, because come on, it's Adora- she can't keep a secret to save her life. But how to deal with the other princesses?

She stands in a perfectly-fitted outfit, in a palace she'd once helped destroy, feeling out of place- like an imposter, posing- and listens as Adora stammers her way through an answer that neither confirms nor denies the question. Perhaps she'll never be free of her past- never make up for her mistakes. Perhaps that's why Adora won't publicly claim her- because why would she want to be associated with Catra's dark history?

She turns away, feeling rejected for a multitude of reasons, and hears Adora call faintly after her, but she slips away in the crowd. Adora doesn't actually really want her, does she?

"Adora! Hi," Entrapta says enthusiastically, appearing suddenly in Adora's path, and Adora curses under her breath as she loses sight of Catra.

"Brother!" Wrong Hordak greets with a smile, and Adora's eyes fall to the neat bowtie at his neck before scanning over his shoulder, searching.

"Hey, Entrapta, and uh- Wrong Hordak," she returns distractedly. Then, lower, she adds, "Did we ever figure out a name for him or are we just going to keep calling him *Wrong Hordak* forever?"

"What's wrong with that?" Entrapta wonders. "He likes his name, don't you, Wrong Hordak?"

"It is an honor to have a name," he agrees with a nod.

"Okay, then," Adora relents. "Is uh… Regular Hordak here, too?"

"Oh, sure! He's grabbing me a drink- did you know they have vini berry juice here?"

"Uh- no! I didn't." After a beat, she realizes that Catra's disappeared, and her heart sinks in fear and disappointment in herself- why couldn't she just spit it out?

They stand in awkward silence as Adora sorts through her distracted thoughts. She let Catra down- *again*. She'd thought that maybe she'd been crazy when Catra returned from Dryl, overjoyed to see her and glued to her side for the rest of their time before parting for Salineas. How could she think Catra's mad at her when she's squeezing her hand, purring beside her, looking at her like she's everything? The memory makes her feel sick, and she's just about to excuse herself to pursue Catra when Entrapta begins speaking again.

“So, Adora,” she starts, clearly trying her best at social interactions. “What’re you going to do now that you’re not She-Ra anymore?”

“Um. I’m still She-Ra; I didn’t lose my powers or anything-”

“Yeah, but the Horde no longer exists. Isn’t that what She-Ra was for? Fighting the Horde?”

Adora’s mind spins. She scans the crowd of people, trying to decide on a direction to begin her search, while her thoughts tangle and crash from Entrapta’s question. “I- *no*. There’s plenty of things for She-Ra to do.”

“Oh,” Entrapta says, genuinely interested. “Like what?”

“Well... Um, okay, right now I’ve been using my powers to help rebuild.”

Entrapta nods. “Uh-huh, and what about after?”

Adora pauses. She has no idea about *after*. She’d assumed that the Best Friend Squad would be taking off on their next big space adventure *after*, but with Mara‘s old ship still in pristine dumpster condition for the foreseeable future, it’s clear that *after* won’t be happening as soon as she thought. What does she do in the meantime? How does she justify She-Ra’s purpose?

What does a conditioned, trained soldier do during times of peace?

Regular Hordak returns- sporting a bowtie similar to Wrong Hordak’s, but in a different color- with three cups of juice just as Adora reaches the height of her mental crisis. What is she going to do? What is her purpose? She's not a soldier, anymore- she's *nothing*, *has* nothing. The revelation settles cruelly over her mind and she feels like there's not enough oxygen in the room, as if the world is crashing down on her, and she barely hears Regular Hordak apologize for carelessly not bringing her a glass of punch. Dazed, she quickly excuses herself, ignoring the way Entrapta

reassures Regular Hordak as she goes. She needs to find Catra- she has to fix whatever's broken, because she doesn't know if she can survive losing her again, after everything.

Catra senses Glimmer a second before she bumps into her, hearing the Queen of Bright Moon breathe her name before their eyes meet. When Glimmer frowns, Catra knows it's obvious her emotions are written across her face, even without Melog glued to her side. Her space companion had been learning to adjust on their own, to find their own way on a foreign planet teeming with magic and life, and here she is- still stagnant, still struggling to adapt.

She narrows her eyes, her ears flattening in annoyance at the realization that she's made no progress in any real, tangible way- that she still feels just as out of place as she did weeks ago. "Sparkles," she greets tersely.

"Are you okay?"

"What does it look like?" she snaps, though she regrets it instantly; Glimmer has done nothing wrong, and she knows that. Why is she so angry?

Glimmer is unfazed by her harsh tone. "Wanna talk about it?"

"Not really, no." She crosses her arms, trying to close herself off, but Glimmer clearly doesn't get it- or doesn't care.

"Okay, then come with me," she says, linking her arm through the crook of Catra's elbow to pull her along.

"Where are we going?"

"I want to show you something."

Catra can only follow as Glimmer half-drags her outside, grateful and admittedly touched that she didn't just teleport her against her will. "We aren't going into the ocean, are we?"

"You'll see!"

"That doesn't sound like a *NO*-"

Glimmer laughs; when they finally reach the small, intimate harbor attached to the palace, she points to a beautiful, purple-gradient ship tied to the nearby dock, taking a seat on the marble steps. "The *Dragon's Daughter VII*!"

"Why does it look vaguely familiar?" Catra wonders suspiciously as she sits beside Glimmer, her tail curling behind her.

"The *Dragon's Daughter III* wrecked your Horde ship the first time we fought here. And the *Dragon's Daughter IV* aided Bright Moon during your assault."

"Any reason you're bringing up these amazingly fun memories?"

Glimmer turns to gaze deeply, seriously, into Catra's eyes, unsettling her, then refocuses her attention to the nearby ship, gleaming next to the dock. "The first time I came here to Salineas, I put so much pressure on myself to succeed. I wanted to show my mom that I could be a good leader, that I could accomplish the mission. But I failed so many times. I felt- *awful*."

She turns back to Catra, who studies her curiously, wondering where she's going with her confession, and hugs her knees to her chest. "Even later, when I became Queen of Bright Moon, I messed up so bad with the Black Garnet. I never thought I could *ever* come back from that."

Suddenly, Glimmer's meaning becomes clear. Catra tries to swallow the lump in her throat. "You've done so much good, though-"

"So have you," Glimmer insists. When Catra shakes her head, she argues, "Catra, I'm *alive* because of you. So is Adora. So is the whole planet. You may not see what you've done, the good you've contributed- but trust me, the rest of us do. We see *you*. And you've… come a long way, Horde Scum."

"Thanks, Sparkles," Catra says half-heartedly, but she takes a deep breath, her ears flattening. "Speaking of that, uh- I never. Well, I never apologized. About the portal. And- your mom."

"I was angry for a long time," Glimmer says, her tone so intense it makes Catra's tail bristle as the stars in her eyes shine brighter, fiercer. "I *hated you*. All I could think about was how to make you *pay* for what you'd done."

Catra's heartbeat quickens at her words, her fur standing on end from the feeling of such powerful emotions resonating from the woman beside her. "I understand if you still do."

Glimmer turns to her, all trace of amusement gone. "But then I got closer to Shadow Weaver… I experienced her manipulation, her cruelty, firsthand, and I wondered what it must've been like for Adora, but especially? What it must've been like for *you*. I grew up with a loving, supportive mom, but you?" Glimmer gazes into the distance. "I thought about what I would be like if I'd only had *one good thing* in my life, and what it would feel like to lose her… and I remembered the missions that drove us apart- how I would have done *anything* to win, even if it meant losing her… and how far I was willing to go."

"And?" Catra whispers, her voice scratchy, her throat tight with emotion.

Glimmer closes her eyes, then leans in and nudges Catra's shoulder with her own as a smile overtakes her face. "And… we aren't so different, Catra."

They sit in comfortable silence for long moments, listening to the waves lap at the artificial shore and the *Dragon's Daughter VII* bob in the water. Catra finds she enjoys the calming sound, and the slight sting of the salty air. Maybe the ocean isn't that bad- so long as she doesn't have to go *in* it.

Her thoughts drift to Adora, and she wonders how a person can be so pure and forgiving. She gazes up at the stars, winking

overhead, and wishes, not for the first time, that she was more like her.

“It’s overwhelming, isn’t it?” Glimmer says softly after a while.

Catra doesn’t need to ask what she means. “How do you do this all the time?”

“I didn’t, at first. I felt- left out, scared that I was going to be left behind by my friends- that I wasn’t enough.”

“Yeah, well you weren’t left behind,” Catra whispers sadly. “Not like I was.”

“It must’ve been awful,” Glimmer admits, hugging her knees tighter. “And I don’t think I’ve ever apologized, either.”

Catra’s ears perk in surprise. “For what?”

“For taking Adora away.”

“It was her choice,” Catra swallows, feeling that cursed lump rising in her throat again. “She chose to leave.”

“Maybe she did,” Glimmer agrees. “But I always knew.”

“Knew what?”

“That she loved you. It was obvious- even if she didn’t have a clue, yet, herself. You meant something special to her, and you still do. I mean, come on- you’ve gotta admit she fell for your distractions every single time. I mean, who does that, right?”

Catra laughs with her for a moment. “You can always count on Adora to have a one-track mind.” She sighs. “I guess I just- don’t know what to do now.”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean, in the Horde I- had a purpose. And even after, I had a mission to stop Horde Prime. Now that’s over, and- well, Adora’s

She-Ra, and you're the Queen of Bright Moon, and where does that leave me?"

"I guess- I guess that's the fun thing about all this," Glimmer says gently, taking Catra's hand, causing the latter to blush at the friendly, unexpected contact. "You get to figure it out. You can be whoever you want to be, do whatever you want to do- because *you* want to, and not for any other reason."

"Talk about overwhelming."

"It is," Glimmer agrees. "But won't it be fun to try?"

Catra furrows her eyebrows, thinking for a moment. It *would* be fun to try, without the fear of failure- or the voice in her head telling her *this isn't who you are*; to really put in effort and see it rewarded with something successful, something worthwhile. But what can she do? What purpose would she serve?

"How do I compete with this new life she has?"

"That's just it," Glimmer says firmly. "You *don't*. You coexist. You just have to accept that there is no competing- we are all important to her in different ways. I could never have the lifelong friendship that bonding through the trauma in the Horde must've forged for you two. And you can never have the blood bond that Adora and I have from fighting against the Horde together. But that doesn't mean we aren't both important to her."

Catra's ears flatten, and she nods slowly, finally accepting that her place in Adora's heart is solid, everlasting, unconditional- and it hits her suddenly, that while Catra has loved Adora their entire life, *Adora has loved her back*. Despite everything, despite all the pain and anguish she'd caused, she was somehow worthy of Adora's love.

"Hey," Glimmer squeezes her hand before releasing it, calling Catra out of her thoughts, "for what it's worth, I don't think I've ever seen Adora truly happy until you joined us."

“Thanks, Sparkles,” Catra says, a small blush crossing her freckled cheeks. She draws a deep, trembling breath, the weight of her words pressing on her chest as she admits, “I’m so- *so* sorry.”

Glimmer smiles sadly, nodding. “I know. I forgave you a long time ago. Now you just need to forgive yourself.”

“You sound like Perfuma,” Catra mumbles with a roll of her eyes.

“I *may* have been working through some anger issues myself,” Glimmer admits, and they share a laugh. “Similar people, remember?”

“There you two are!” Bow calls, waving as he walks over, and Glimmer and Catra climb to their feet, dusting off their legs in preparation to greet him.

“We were about to send out a Search Party Adventure!” Sea Hawk agrees from behind Bow. “They would search, and I would stay here and *party*.”

“Hey,” Adora says once she reaches them, her voice soft and low as she moves impossibly close to Catra, concerned blue eyes searching for a sign that Catra’s upset with her. “Are you all right?”

Catra glances over Adora’s shoulder to Glimmer, who offers her an encouraging smile and a discreet thumbs up, and she smiles, too. “Yeah. I just needed some air.”

Adora looks between the two, but doesn’t ask any questions about Catra’s disappearance as they walk, hand in hand, back towards the party, leaving Bow with Sea Hawk to admire the *Dragon’s Daughter VII* while Glimmer immediately excuses herself to the restroom.

When the band starts a new, slow song, Adora turns to her. “Will you dance with me?”

Catra smirks as she automatically moves to the dance floor, flicking the tip of her tail across Adora's nose teasingly. "Since when do *you* dance?"

Adora brushes her tail away in amused annoyance as she follows at Catra's heels. "Excuse me, I did really well at Princess Prom before you *ruined* it-"

"And I was *clearly* out of your league." Catra grins and offers Adora her hand, and Adora can't help the way, even now, her heart skips a beat at the sight as she accepts it, letting Catra pull her into her arms, close, intimate.

They sway together, Adora leaning her head against Catra and closing her eyes for a moment. It feels good to do something normal, without worrying about something exploding or being attacked- even though the source of the majority of those attacks was usually the person in her arms. She struggles not to let her fears from earlier- fears for the future, fears of losing She-Ra, not out of incompetence, but out of a lack of need- take over as she focuses on Catra's breathing, on Catra's warmth, on Catra's hand on the small of her back.

"I'm sorry if I upset you earlier," Adora murmurs in a voice barely above a whisper, but Catra can hear her loud and clear despite the loud music, and her ear twitches involuntarily from the tickling sensation of Adora's warm breath.

"You didn't," Catra reassures. "I was just being sensitive."

"No- I should've just told Mermista," Adora insists.

"You can tell her whenever you're ready-"

Adora pulls back, not breaking the embrace but pausing the dance as she stares fiercely into Catra's eyes. "I *am* ready, Catra. I'm not ashamed of you, or of us being together. I just didn't want to overwhelm or overshadow you." Her voice grows small, scared, and tears begin to well up in her eyes, causing Catra to feel slightly panicked. "I don't want it to be like it was before, in the

Fright Zone- I don't want you to live in my shadow, resenting me for holding you back, lying about being content with second place."

Now it's Catra's turn to feel tears building; she takes slow, controlled breaths. "It won't be like that," Catra whispers, burying her face in Adora's neck to hide her tears. "I promise I'll speak up this time, if it happens- I won't lie."

Adora squeezes her close, holding her tightly as they resume dancing, finishing the song. She takes Catra's hand and leads her from the dance floor, finding Mermista and Sea Hawk by the kelp bar.

"So you found her," Mermista states casually.

"Yeah, and to answer your question- yes. We are an item now," Adora says firmly, squeezing Catra's hand. Catra just blushes, but her tail swishes happily.

"Well, that's *excellent* news," Sea Hawk says seriously. "Congratulations on a powerful and well-matched pairing, the likes of which I have never before witnessed other than Mermista and myself."

"Is he always like this?" Catra whispers loudly.

"Welcome to the team," Mermista shrugs wearily, downing her drink, then flagging down her staff. "Butler, *another...*"

They steal away from the party after, onto the balcony, watching the stars as they lean against the railing, and each other.

"I meant to tell you earlier, but- you look stunning," Catra says, without missing a beat, without malice, just all charm, and Adora blushes at the compliment. She's not sure Catra's ever admitted something like that. It makes her heart race. "You always do."

"Thank you," she says shyly. "You have nice clothes as well."

Catra wrinkles her nose. “Thanks?”

“I’m sorry- I’m sorry,” Adora stammers quickly. “I just- you look gorgeous, Catra, and I don’t even know what to say.”

“Adora, it’s okay.” Catra smiles, a soft smile that shows her fangs, and Adora relaxes, leaning into her again as she plays with Catra’s fingers, tracing hers over the back of her hand, along her forearm, and down.

“The sky is so different, now,” Catra comments gently, breaking the comfortable silence that had fallen over them. “I don’t know if I’ll ever get used to seeing stars.”

Adora looks up, her eyes tracing the flecks of light in the dark sky. “Is it bad?”

“No,” Catra averts her eyes to their tangled fingers. “I used to stare at them a lot- on Prime’s ship. Before I was- well, before.”

Adora presses her lips together, recalling that scary, emotional time. She squeezes Catra’s hand in encouragement.

“The starlight reminds me of you,” Catra admits softly. “They have that same glow that you have….”

Adora swallows, fear quickening her heartbeat. *What does a soldier do once they've won the war?* “When I’m She-Ra?”

“No,” Catra shakes her head. “Just… when you’re you, Adora.”

Feeling as if she might cry, Adora pulls Catra into a tight hug, and they stand on the balcony, holding each other, until Bow comes to collect them to head home.

Cosmic Love

Chapter Notes

Hiiiiii readers! :)

I'm so sorry this chapter took forever!! Cat sex is hard. D:
I hope you enjoy it, regardless.

Thanks once again to everyone who read, commented, kudos-ed or bookmarked the story. I appreciate you and I really hope you like this last chapter, but no pressure.

This chapter is spicy, and I'd like to thank one of my best writing besties, Dakota, for being my Forever Wall. They are literally awesome.

Enjoy~

then I heard your heart beating, you were in the darkness, too
so I stayed in the darkness with you

As Catra's staff barely misses her stomach- thanks solely to a well-timed dodge- Adora wonders if she's made a grave mistake.

She's always known that Catra is faster than her, with quicker reflexes, far superior senses and natural fighting instincts. She's almost always been outmatched as her normal self- and yet, here she is, some sort of idiot masochist. She blocks a fast- Catra's *so fast*- advance from her staff and attempts to deliver a blow of her own, but another talent that Catra's always possessed is the ability to predict her movement; she knows Adora so well that she knows what Adora's going to do, sometimes even before Adora does.

She used to assume that it was just part of Catra being a prepared soldier, part of Catra's competitive nature, but now Adora wonders if it's due to the fact that Catra has loved her- wanted her- their whole lives, and a faint blush crosses her cheeks. Catra smirks when she notices it, but doesn't let up her brutal assault, and Adora feels slight embarrassment creep up on her from the fact that her feelings are quite obviously affecting her performance.

When Catra finally slams her onto her back on the mat, her staff locked against hers across her chest, pinning her to the ground, Adora realizes that this exercise is not helping Catra relax or release any residual anger she may be holding onto. She'd hoped, when she'd found Catra in their shared bedroom, perched on the windowsill and absently gazing outside with her tail flicking back and forth- a sign of her deep, heavy thoughts- that an offer to spar might help her with whatever she was clearly wrestling with. After all, a good work-out and a few blows to her head always made Adora feel better, and Catra didn't turn her down, but-

"Give, Princess?" Catra purrs, her tail flicking in triumph as she presses down just slightly harder, and Adora grunts.

"Do you feel better?"

Catra pauses, letting up slightly, but doesn't show any crack in her smug expression. "Do I feel better having proven my ultimate dominance over you?" She shrugs carelessly, as if this is just another average, meaningless activity to her. "Nah. I already knew my skills are far superior-"

Adora shoves upward with all her strength, sending Catra hurtling back unsteadily with a yelp, and she quickly rolls to her feet, smirking as she brings her staff up, signaling she's ready for another round. Their eyes meet, and Adora can't help the way her heart races- will it ever stop doing that?

They continue sparring, and Adora acts almost on autopilot, her responses so ingrained in her that she doesn't need to think about

them, her thoughts drifting. Catra continues to basically beat her ass, predicting her every move, and she can't help recalling the last time they'd fought each other- when Catra was chipped. It makes her stomach turn, remembering the way she'd held Catra *after*- broken, lifeless in her arms.

It reminds her that they still have so much to talk about. She hasn't exactly been avoiding it, she just has no idea how to start the conversation. Again she's reminded of her original intentions, and the hope that this familiar act would help them loosen up, but instead she feels the exact opposite: tension invades her body the longer they grapple, and she can feel the anger radiating from Catra, despite the fact that she knows Catra is still holding most of it back. It causes anger to surface in her, as well- anger and, admittedly, excitement. Catra's lithe movement and nearly palpable fury is somehow incredibly attractive, but her graceful form coupled with the recollection of feelings from when Adora had thought she'd lost her makes Adora's stomach clench with fear and, bizarrely, *desire*, and all Adora wants to do is kiss her.

The sudden realization that the need to kiss Catra is jarringly familiar, that she's unknowingly felt it every time they'd fought in the past, causes her to misstep, and Catra does not miss the opportunity to advance, backing her against the wall.

"What're you thinking about?" Catra demands, sharp eyes narrowed in suspicion. "You've got that dumb look on your face."

"The last time we fought," Adora blurts, sucking in a huge gulp of air in an effort to catch her breath, her heart pounding fiercely- not from exertion, but from remembered emotion, from aching want- in her chest. "And- kissing you." She licks her bottom lip, and her stomach tightens as she notices Catra's bright eyes follow the movement.

"Oh," Catra rumbles quietly. She lessens the pressure on Adora's shoulder, straightening up.

“I think - I think I’ve always wanted to kiss you," Adora admits. Catra offers her a soft smile, understanding her meaning without explaining.

“So do it, then.”

Adora’s blue eyes sparkle with excitement as she leans in to press her smile to Catra’s lips. But despite the way her own body responds, despite the way that Catra mumbles, *me, too* before kissing her back with desperate longing, Adora can feel that she’s still holding back, still holding on to something that puts distance between them, and she knows that she needs to address it… but how?

“I just don’t know what to do about it,” Adora says miserably, hugging one knee to her chest.

“Maybe try talking to her?” Glimmer offers, tilting a watering can over a patch of the surviving plants in Shadow Weaver’s garden. Many of them had magical properties and uses, and since she’d originally had them brought from Mystacor, she figures that it’s in her best interest to keep them alive. Glimmer had found a new teacher in her father, who, like Shadow Weaver, understood the need to be limitless and progressive with sorcery, to not be restricted by the ancient, brittle rules of Mystacor- a sore subject with her aunt, Castaspella.

“She opened up *surprisingly* easily," she continues, bending to inspect the petals on a flower shaped like a skull. "I think she wants to talk to you, she probably just doesn’t know how, either. This is new territory for both of you.”

Adora agrees with a wistful nod. ”I’m just- not the best at this.”

“You do tend to be very up front with things,” Glimmer shrugs. “And Catra’s not the best with straight up confrontation.” She pauses, thoughtful for a moment, before turning her attention to

some thorned vines. “Here's an idea- why don’t you take her on a date?”

“A *date*?” Adora panics at the thought. “Where? What do I do? What do I wear?”

Glimmer turns and places her hand on her shoulder, finding her eyes, an amused grin on her face. “Adora? Relax. It’s not that kind of date. I meant, just take her somewhere private, so you can talk. And then just be yourself. It’s *Catra*- she’s going to enjoy it as long as you don’t put her near any water.”

“Right,” she laughs nervously, “*right*, so- where should I take her, exactly?”

Glimmer shrugs, turning back to her inherited plants. One of them has really started to flourish, which is impressive, considering the length of its neglect. “Somewhere special, I guess.”

Adora bites her lip, trying to think of a special place for them that wasn’t just recently demolished or destroyed. She watches Glimmer water some more plants that look like spiderwebs, trying to think of somewhere important, somewhere meaningful that doesn't also include a memory of them battling, and then, it hits her.

“I know where I want to take her,” she says softly. “But I need your help.”

“What is this?” Catra asks as they stop outside of the palace, and she takes in the floating, gray hunk of metal parked there. It looks painfully out of place, standing out dramatically from the clean, pink and purple palette behind it.

“Um- a skiff. I thought that part was obvious,” Adora says as she walks up to it and awkwardly pats it.

“No, duh,” Catra sighs with a roll of her eyes. “I meant, why is it here, in Bright Moon, instead of some shady black market scrap

pile somewhere in the Crimson Waste?”

“Oh! Right- Scorpia let me borrow one. I, um- want to take you somewhere.” Adora holds her breath, but she knows Catra will not deny her. Catra has never denied her, not since their reunion, but still, the fear of rejection from years ago- when she'd practically begged her to leave the Horde and come with her- lingers.

Catra’s eyebrow twitches, but she says nothing as she leaps gracefully onto the skiff, rolling her eyes again at the surge of excitement she can feel pouring off of Adora beside her. She glances towards her and finds her staring at her, blue eyes bright, soft smile on her lips.

“What?” Catra demands, feeling awkward at being the center of all Adora’s attention. Awkward, and secretly flattered.

Adora shrugs, but doesn’t tear her eyes away. “You dressed different.”

Catra blushes, her tail flicking in embarrassment. “Yeah, well, we aren’t in a war anymore,” she mutters. “And Sparkles convinced me to wear clothes for *comfort* instead of functionality, though I don’t see what the problem is with my old ones if that’s the case-”

“You look really nice,” Adora breathes, and Catra blushes harder, her eyes widening, tail and ears dropping in surprise. Catra is still in skin-tight dark pants with no shoes, but her top is lighter, slightly looser, and still sleeveless. A high, v-neck collar, similar to her former uniform, cradles her neck but drops to expose just the top of her collarbones. It's familiar, but different, and Adora bites her lip as her eyes appreciate the change and the newly-exposed skin.

“Thanks,” Catra finally manages, trying to ignore the way her heartbeat picks up from the look Adora's giving her. “You look nice, too.” Adora glances down at herself- unlike Catra, she’s still in her usual clothes, but when she finds Catra’s eyes, and sees no

malice or humor there, only genuine and fond admiration, she smiles.

“Thanks,” she says shyly, and continues blushing even as she fires up the skiff and they speed, steadily, towards the Whispering Woods.

“So, where are we going?”

“You’ll see,” Adora says mysteriously, but Catra is not overly concerned- they don’t seem to be heading towards any water, and the skiff would never make it to Mystacor, so she feels safe and reassured that Adora isn't ambushing her with anything.

As they ride in comfortable silence- other than the sound of the skiff's rickety engine, of course- they both lose themselves in thought, musing over how much they've changed. Right away, Adora notices that Catra doesn’t fight her for control of the skiff; after all, in the three years that have passed since their last skiff adventure, Catra had controlled the entire Horde army, could ride any vehicle she’d wanted- and still, to Catra, nothing could ever compare to this moment, soaring through the trees, with Adora. So despite not elbowing her for the stick, her eyes are bright and ears alert with happiness as they steal through the dark woods.

The sense of nostalgia, of deja vu, does not escape her notice, however. They drive deeper and her stomach tightens with creeping dread as she recalls how her life had changed so drastically after that first time in the woods- and even though she knows otherwise, she can’t help the fear, the worry that sinks into her at the thought that something bad could happen, again.

Steering through the trees, her eyes scanning for a familiar landmark, Adora contemplates how much her friendship with Catra has evolved, and not for the worst; she doesn’t feel that competitive edge that used to linger over them because of the Horde. She knows now that it was the drive for attention, for recognition, but now there’s nothing to compete for except their own amusement. She takes her eyes off their destination for a

moment to observe Catra again- she's quiet, seemingly enjoying her surroundings, appreciative. She wonders if it's because of Horde Prime or because of her own growth- can the two even be separated? Would she have grown if Horde Prime hadn't done whatever he'd done to her?

The fact that she still doesn't know what happened somewhat bothers her- but she will *never* ask Catra about it. Glimmer had told her, in hushed tones after they'd rescued her, about Prime's green pool, but even she didn't know the extent of Catra's suffering (she trembles as she recalls that Horde Prime had used the word *suffering)* and they'd never brought it up again. She wasn't sure, even now, that she wanted to know, because there's nothing she could do except go crazy with the knowledge. Horde Prime no longer existed, their revenge had been taken- but the damage had already been done, and would be part of Catra forever.

With a heavy breath, she pushes those thoughts away, focusing instead on where she's bringing Catra.

They have other healing to do.

Adora slows the skiff to a stop as she begins to recognize the small clearing that is their ultimate destination. She parks it, somewhat shakily- she'd only driven it one time, years ago, so she's not the best- and jumps to the ground as Catra climbs to her feet, tail swishing nervously behind her.

"This is it!" Adora walks out into the center of the clearing, the starlight illuminating the ground, reflecting off the golden puffs of magic and surrounding fog. She turns to Catra, reaching out her hand, reminding Catra of the day they defeated Prime, with a dumb, hopeful expression on her face. Catra accepts her hand and allows Adora to pull her into her arms. "Where it all started," she whispers, pressing her forehead to Catra's, her eyes dropping to her lips.

“Where you found that stupid sword,” Catra mutters in realization, the memory making her heart clench painfully, and her stomach drop in fear.

“It still bothers you,” Adora states, as if realizing it for the first time. Her grip on Catra lessens as she pulls back to study her face. “That I left?”

Catra laughs, shakily, bitterly. “You thought three years of heartbreak would just disappear?”

Adora swallows, her fear spiking as she recalls Chipped Catra’s words- *you broke my heart*. Her stomach twists, heart plummets at the thought that those were Catra’s true words, and not Horde Prime’s. “Is that really what you felt? I thought it was just Horde Prime-"

Catra glares at her. “How could you not *know* that, Adora?”

“Well, you’re not exactly the easiest person to read.”

Catra laughs, despite her anger. “I guess I should wear every dumb emotion on my face, like you.”

Adora offers her idiotic, trademark grin. “It would help.”

They gaze into each other’s eyes; Catra feels her anger fading, but there’s still so much left unsaid, and so many questions in her mind. She's not an idiot- she knows Adora brought her here for a reason. She also knew Adora had been trying to get her to open up for the last several days, and it was admittedly both infuriating and adorable. She can't keep holding onto her resentment, though- not if she wants this thing with Adora to last. And First Ones, does she want it to last. So, with a deep breath, she takes the plunge.

“Did you ever want to come back?” she wonders softly, hugging her arms, her ears drooping, terrified of the answer.

Adora's chest feels tight. "All the time. I missed you so bad, Catra. I…" She pauses, gathering her emotions, composing herself. She takes Catra's hand, pulling her arm away from her chest, and strokes the back with her thumb, her blue eyes watching the movement through building tears to distract from the memory. "My heart was broken, too."

Catra's ear twitches, and she gazes at Adora out of the corner of her eye. "I'm sorry," she admits quietly, the words becoming more familiar each time she says them. "If only I had just left the stupid Horde-"

"Shh," Adora reassures, leaning her forehead against Catra's again, keeping her voice soft, intimate. She squeezes her hand. "You're here, now." They stand in silence for a moment, lost in the emotions, in the memories, and each other's proximity. And then, Adora asks in a small, unsteady, unsure voice,

"Did you ever want to?"

"Leave the Horde?" Catra clarifies, pulling away to gaze into Adora's striking, vulnerable eyes. At her reassuring nod, Catra squeezes her eyes shut in anguish for a moment, recalling the pain she had felt when Adora didn't return- as if she'd lost part of herself. She recalls how many times she had to talk herself out of leaving the Horde, telling herself that she would never fit in with the prissy princesses, that her friendship with Adora would never be the same, anyways, that Adora liked her new friend Sparkles better than her, and that Adora would never return her feelings; that all their dreams were *dead*. She recalls how many times she had to talk herself out of leaving, and yet still her heart had leapt with hope- traitorous, stupid hope- that Adora wanted her, that Adora missed her, that it wouldn't be like her self-doubt told her it would-

"Every day," Catra breathes finally. "I missed you, too. But-"

Adora kisses her then, stealing her words. They get lost for long moments, and when she pulls back, breathless, her blue eyes

sparkle. “It’s time for us to start over,” she says firmly. Then, with less confidence, she continues, “It’s why I brought you here. I want- I want us to take those memories back. The Horde is gone, but our friendship- and, like, you know, *more*- is still here. It will be, forever.”

Catra smiles, really smiles, her heart pounding with that same, stupid hope at Adora's warm words. “Promise?”

Adora grins, nudging their noses together. “I *promise*.”

When Adora kisses her again, and Catra feels all her bittersweet remorse transform, feels her heaviness lift, she finally, finally begins to believe it.

They kiss until they’re out of breath. Adora’s hands hold Catra’s face tightly, and she aches to be closer as the tension builds the more Catra’s tongue swipes teasingly at her bottom lip. When Catra cups the back of her neck and firmly grabs her hip to pull her closer, against her body, Adora feels as if she will overheat. She pulls back for air and quickly twists out of her red jacket, stumbling for only a moment, before pressing forward again, her arms locking tightly around Catra’s waist and their mouths meeting, harder, fiercer than before. She nearly melts as Catra tugs her hairtie free and threads fingers through her hair, her nails lightly scratching her scalp, causing a shudder of pleasure to rip through her.

Catra is the one to break the kiss so that her mouth can press kisses along Adora's jaw before pausing to kiss beneath her ear. Her fingertips dip briefly beneath the hem of her tight, long-sleeved shirt, teasing her heated skin, causing her stomach to tremble, and Adora feels as if she’s suffocating, her heart slamming in her chest as Catra’s lips burn a path down her neck. She struggles with something she's struggled with her entire life- *restraint*. In her mind, she urges herself to give in, to just feel and allow herself to indulge in something she wants so much it aches. Her hands find Catra’s hair, fingers burying in the short, choppy locks as Catra’s mouth finally returns to hers and they kiss again,

teeth and tongues clashing. Adora presses her hips forward, releasing a frustrated moan at the lack of friction, and Catra pulls back to stare into her darkened blue eyes, swallowing nervously.

“Do you still- you know, want me?”

“Of course,” Adora whispers, her breath heavy and fast, her cheeks tinged pink with desire. “You’re everything to me, Catra.”

When their mouths meet again, Adora presses forward and carefully lowers them both to the soft, cushioned ground, covered in thick moss, her arm supporting them beneath Catra’s shoulders. They don’t stay that way for long; Catra twists up to suck at Adora’s pulse point, and Adora leans back, overwhelmed with the feeling, especially when Catra's fingertips slip beneath her shirt, more daring than before, and burn a path across her stomach. She trembles as they move higher, but Catra's hands don't slow as they bring the tough fabric of Adora's shirt with them. Catra tosses the white fabric aside before pushing Adora, shirtless, to the ground beside them. Catra rolls with her and ends up on top, straddling her hips and causing Adora's heart to slam against her ribcage at the sight of Catra above her, so different from the many times they'd been in a similar position over the course of their lives.

Overwhelmed with desire, Adora sits up, her abs flexing beneath Catra’s fingers, and their lips meet again. Adora’s hands rake through Catra’s hair and Catra tugs her shirt over her head and tosses it away, revealing her bare chest to Adora- not for the first time, but for the first time in such a weighted context. Shrugging away her minor insecurity, her hips grind down into Adora's lap, almost automatically, and a shiver rolls down her spine at the way Adora's breath hitches from the contact. Adora runs her hands reverently along Catra’s sides, over her chest, around her back, enjoying the feel of velvet skin beneath her fingers as she cradles her close and drives Catra crazy from her touch. She can't withhold the moan that tumbles from her throat when her bare chest presses against Catra’s for the first time, and Catra echoes the sentiment. Catra is warm and so soft, it makes Adora’s arms

tighten around her small frame and kiss her harder. When she pulls back, panting, her blue eyes searching Catra's face, Catra feels her stomach drop with fear.

“What is it?”

Adora licks her bottom lip, her gaze trailing along Catra’s lips, her neck, down to her slightly heaving chest and back up to her familiar, warm eyes. “It’s just- I’ve wanted this- *you*- for so long,” she admits, her voice thick with need. “But I could never admit it to myself, or let myself think that we could have this- not until the other night.” She squeezes Catra’s hips, awed and painfully aroused, and her eyes drop to the lithe form beneath her hands. Catra's throat tightens with emotion as Adora continues in a whisper, her blue eyes shining, “I've never allowed myself to want anything. But it’s you… it’s always been you. I’m sorry it took me nearly dying to figure it out.”

Catra chuckles shakily, feeling overwhelmed from the confession and the way it echoes her own heart. “Melog was right.”

Adora grins lopsidedly. “What?”

Catra shakes her head. “It doesn’t matter. I’m sorry it took you nearly dying for me to tell you how I felt.”

“At least we didn’t die,” Adora grins, and Catra rolls her eyes before leaning in for another kiss, which turns into another, and another, until Catra moans in her mouth, her hips rolling against her, reminding her of her own aching need.

Adora hesitates; she knows what Catra wants, but her total lack of experience causes her to second-guess herself. She slides her hands gently along Catra’s thighs, nervously meeting her gaze, and the heaviness of the moment settles over them. In answer, Catra shifts, sliding her dark, tight pants and gray undergarments down and off before settling back into Adora’s lap. Adora sucks in a breath as Catra kisses her again, urgently, waiting for Adora to initiate the next step. She curls her tail along Adora’s’s calf,

anchoring herself, trembling in anticipation for Adora to touch her, and finally, Adora's brain kick-starts and her hands return to Catra's thighs, now bare.

"You're so soft," Adora breathes, her blue eyes tracing down and drawn immediately to Catra's center, on display in her lap. Adora swallows her nerves, her hand trembling as she slides her hand along Catra's inner thigh, and Catra can practically feel her nervousness- so unlike the normally confident and poised Adora- as she bites her bottom lip.

Catra, her center throbbing, grabs Adora's hand, gently guiding it in encouragement between her legs; Adora gasps as Catra guides two fingers to press against her slick entrance, then releases her hand.

Their eyes meet and hold; they both hold their breath, and then Adora pushes upwards, breaking the last barrier between them. Catra's thighs tense, tightening around her as she presses deeper, amazed at how soft Catra is, how her fingers move so easily, and then she's completely inside her, and her heart feels as if it's going to take flight. Catra clutches the back of her neck tightly, sharing breath as Adora moves her fingers, starting a soft, gentle rhythm, and then their mouths are together, and Catra's hips are rocking down sharply, and-

"A-adora," Catra pants, holding her tighter as she gets closer and closer to the edge.

"I've got you," Adora pants, echoing Catra's sentiment from days ago, her arm around Catra's lower back pulling her even closer. "I'm not letting go."

Their eyes meet, hold. Catra's thighs tremble, her body tenses, but she doesn't break eye contact. She feels the pressure building in her from the steady, smooth movement of Adora's fingers inside her, feels raw under Adora's dark, intense, loving- always so *damn loving*- gaze, feels as if she will shake apart from the build-up of pressure inside her.

She cries out as her release hits her with blinding, sudden force, squeezing her thighs and gasping as Adora continues to move gently inside her, though it's significantly harder with how hard Catra's inner walls are strangling her fingers. Catra buries her face into Adora's neck, struggling to catch her breath for long moments, her body trembling. Adora just holds her with one arm wrapped securely around her waist, her other trapped between Catra's legs, feeling her pulse around her fingers. Finally, Catra lifts her head and presses a slow, open-mouthed kiss to Adora's lips. When they pull back, Adora bites her lip, unbearably turned on from the way Catra is still clenching around her fingers, and amazed at the amount of wetness pooled in her palm. She wants to speak, to describe how incredible the moment was for her, but she's at a loss for words, especially when Catra's kisses begin to trail down her neck.

Before she can protest, Adora's being pushed down onto her back, and Catra's hovering above her, her hands sliding across her breasts, teasing the tense, hard muscle of her stomach, tracing the sharp V of her hips. Adora bucks upwards uncontrollably at the touch, and Catra grins in pleasure at having gotten her so completely riled before she's tugging Adora's pants and undershorts off. Adora bites her lip, her blue eyes finding Catra's dark ones once more, and Catra's grin softens into a loving smile. She cups Adora's cheek, stroking gentle fingers down her face, and Adora turns her head to plant a kiss on Catra's palm, stealing her breath.

Her hand resting on Adora's hip slides lower, across her thigh, and Adora shivers in anticipation as Catra pauses. Carefully, she retracts her claws, concentrating on keeping them sheathed, and strokes a finger along Adora's entrance, gathering wetness and stroking up over the spot that makes Adora's thighs tense around her.

She cautiously presses a finger to her entrance, and then it's her turn to be amazed at how soft and wet Adora is for her; she concentrates harder.

“Do it, please,” Adora breathes in enamored encouragement. “I trust you, Catra.”

With the receipt of so much trust, and the excited energy of having Adora where she’s wanted her for years pushing on the edge of her senses, Catra takes a deep breath and presses her hand forward, entering Adora in one smooth, easy motion. Adora is tight and slick around her finger, and as she pushes deeper, Adora grabs her wrist, holding it tightly as she breathes heavily at the feeling- not to stop her action, but to feel more connected.

When Adora leans up and kisses her, Catra adds another finger, nearly breaking her concentration when Adora moans, hot and low, into her mouth-

And then she’s moving inside her, and Adora is tensing beneath her, her hips rocking upwards, desperate to meet Catra’s careful thrusts, and when their eyes meet, Catra feels indescribable warmth fill her.

“Catra,” Adora says breathlessly, wrapping arms around her, hugging her close, and Catra allows herself to be held to her chest, though it makes her thrusting more difficult, allows the sound of her name from Adora’s lips to fill her with warmth, to soothe the ache of her distant pining. Their naked bodies press together and Catra memorizes the moment, forgetting everything but the way Adora tightens around her fingers, the way Adora clings to her, desperate, as if Catra is all she needs in the world- and Catra lets it chase away every bitter feeling of hopeless longing she’d been holding onto.

The thought that Adora truly belongs to her, now, fills her with a heat she cannot name, so different than how she felt when Adora was inside her, claiming her- after all, she knows she has always belonged to Adora, but now the connection is reciprocated.

The night sky fills Adora’s vision as Catra takes her to a higher plane of existence and her body begins to tense. Stars- so foreign to her in the past- seem so familiar to her now, and she feels as if

she is in space again, elevated, flying among them, closer and closer with each thrust of Catra's fingers inside her.

When Adora squeezes her tighter, Catra knows she's close. She keeps a steady pace, keeps steady eye contact from her spot resting on Adora's chest, and when Adora comes- for her- her heart feels as if it might explode from the weight of such an intense feeling.

Catra turns her head, pressing her ear to Adora's chest as she trembles, listening to the erratic pounding of her heart slow to a rhythmic thrumming as Adora pets fingers lovingly through her short hair.

They lay there for long moments, catching their breath, cuddling and basking in the afterglow. Adora traces lazy fingertips down along Catra's spine, causing her to shiver, but it's not an unpleasant feeling, so Catra doesn't leave her position on Adora's chest.

Adora gazes up at the stars, her thoughts scattered as she struggles to come back to her body from space. The stars- not unlike her feelings- her love- for Catra.

"It's just crazy to think that they were always there, all along," she mumbles, still in a haze of bliss. "We just didn't know. We just needed to change our surroundings, and… there they are."

Catra glances up at her face, confused, but when she follows her gaze to the night sky, she repositions and smiles, snuggling closer against her, with the stars framing her view. Adora's meaning is not lost on her, but the realization makes her fondness of the stars grow, and the feeling in her chest expand.

"The stars have always been there," Catra repeats in a quiet, loving tone.

Adora smiles wider. Her eyes soften. "And they always will be."

“I want to show you something,” Adora says gently as she climbs to her feet and slips on a shirt.

From her back on their shared bed, catching her breath, Catra mutters, “Really, Adora? Now?”

Adora grins sheepishly but pulls on boots, and Catra sighs, her thighs still shaking after several rounds of intense lovemaking. She wants nothing more than to pass out, maybe return the favor, but instead she rolls out of bed and wordlessly pulls on clothes, because it’s not like she can ever deny Adora anything, anyway.

Once dressed, Adora shoots her a grateful smile and slips her hand into hers, then leads them outside, onto their balcony, and to the right edge, where a newly-installed permanent ladder connects to the wall.

Catra narrows her eyes, her ear twitching. “Where did that come from?”

Adora shrugs. “Glimmer had it installed while we were gone the other night, at my request.”

Catra furrows her eyebrows. “Why? Where does it go?”

“Let’s find out,” Adora says mischievously, and Catra can’t help but smile at the familiar smirk.

It takes a while to climb the ladder, and there are several more after the initial one, taking them above the palace and up the purple-hued rock spires surrounding it, before finally ending on a large rock ledge jutting out from the back side of one of the spires. A glance at her surroundings confirms that the spire completely blocks any view of the palace of Bright Moon, but stretched out endlessly below them is the Whispering Woods, ethereal and shrouded in a gentle, magic glow. Even further in the distance are the sharp, curved rocks surrounding the Fright Zone, hazy and barely visible.

The view is breathtaking and a little overwhelming, but one thought plagues Catra's mind: “How did you ever find this place?”

“I didn’t. This is the first time I’ve been here.” When Catra raises her eyebrow doubtfully, Adora shrugs. “Really. I wanted us to have a place that could be ours- like, um, before.” She takes a deep breath. “Look- I know this life, Bright Moon, the princesses- it can be a lot. And it's probably not one you ever wanted or expected. But I want you to know that when it becomes too much, we still have a place we can go that’s only ours.”

“And, obviously, Sparkles’.”

Adora shakes her head. “She’d never come up here. She hates views like this.”

"What? Why?"

"They remind her of how insignificant she is or something, I don't know."

Catra gazes out fondly into the distance, eyes drawn to the woods, and she blushes as she remembers the night she'd shared with Adora there. She turns her gaze to Adora, her heart filled with so much love and gratitude she doesn't think she could ever express it out loud, and realizes that it doesn't matter where they go, her favorite view is, and has always been, the one that's right before her. “I think I could get used to it,” she says softly, leaning in.

Their lips meet in a sweet kiss, and when Catra pulls back, she smiles again. “Adora, thank you for this. I don’t know what the future holds- or what I’m doing, like, at all-”

“Me either,” Adora agrees.

“But I know that whatever it is, whatever I figure out, I want to do it with you.” Her ears flatten shyly as she admits, "*That's* the life that I wanted."

Adora heart swells, and she feels weak, melting against Catra as she nuzzles into her. “So does that mean you’ll take on the world with me again?”

Catra can’t help the purr that rumbles up from her chest, especially when Adora’s hand finds hers, and their cheeks press together. Etheria stretches out before them, but her eyes slip closed, and she focuses instead on the heart beating next to her, and striking, loving blue eyes. “The world doesn’t stand a chance.”

End Notes

Thanks for reading!! And always, you're welcome to leave feedback, but if not, it's okay!! Some people like to be ghosts! (re: me)

I know I said I'd never write SPOP again, but we are currently doing a re-watch in my household soooo who knows with me. I could get inspired, it happens at the worst possible times, after all.

See you next time, in which I will be writing a LOK fic, because I hate myself!!! :D

titles of the chapters come from songs by these incredible artists:

Maps by Yeah Yeah Yeahs
Your Best American Girl by mitski, a forever mood
Posing for Cars by jbrekkie, the LEGENDARY
Cosmic Love by Florence + The Machine, the goddess

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